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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting, Thursday, July 22, 2021

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q7jOfPX5wi4
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:06:01] so we're going to wait for just a minute till we get one moment of silence followed by the pledge

[00:08:07] of allegiance okay a few quick opening comments uh first you know you heard me uh ask if pam was

[00:08:47] here. That's actually Dr. Davis Vaught, who is participating with us electronically today, as provided in our bylaws. The reason is medical, and her location is Bristol, Virginia. I think that satisfies, so if there's no challenge to that, we will move on. I will say, before we get to the election of president and vice president, how delighted the board is to be back in, you know, our own space. We appreciated the governor lending us Patrick Henry last month, but honestly, there's no place like home. And, you know, it's kind of nice. It's also nice to have people coming back for a public comment. Although, there you go. Thank you. Give yourselves a round of applause

[00:09:26] because it has been a long while. I think it's been actually 18 months since we've been at a meeting in this room with, you know, people. And so, you know, glad to see we're at this point. You know, my two-year term, I guess, ends in a few days. However, you know, today is the day appointed for election of president and vice president. So I'm going to turn the meeting over to Dr. Lane. Thank you, Mr. Gecker. We now open the floor for nominations for the president of the

[00:09:58] Board of Education. With gratitude for your prior service, I hereby nominate Dan Gecker to continue serving as president. I second that. Okay. We have a motion and a second. Any other nominations?

[00:10:16] Hearing none, we'll close nominations. We'll now vote on Mr. Gecker to serve as president of the Board of Education. Since we are in person, except for a roll call for Ms. Davis-Vaugh, I guess, but we will all in favor say aye.

[00:10:34] Aye. Aye. And Ms. Davis-Vaugh says aye. Any opposed? Mr. Gecker, you are once again elected president. Thank you. You know, I used to think being elected president was a recognition of skill and capability, And I've come to learn that what it really does is it recognizes the fact that I have no life outside of this.

[00:10:54] And so as the least busy board member, I get to do this for another couple of years. I will say that it has been, you know, a great privilege, honestly, to work with this group over the last four and look forward to, you know, continuing the work as set out in the comprehensive work plan as we move on to the next two years.

[00:11:15] With that, the election of vice president, are there any nominations for vice presidents of the Board of Education? Yes, President Gecker, I would like to, I'm proud to nominate Dr. Jamel Wilson for her continued service, and I look forward to her continuing to lead us on our work, Dr. Jamel Wilson.

[00:11:33] Thank you. Thank you, Dr. Duran. Is there a second? I second that. Are there any other nominations? Seeing none, we'll close nominations. All in favor of Dr. Wilson being Vice President of the Board of Ed for the next two years, signify by saying aye.

[00:11:52] Aye. Any opposed? Thank you, Dr. Davis-Vaught. Any opposed? Clearly not. You know, Dr. Wilson is the, you know, second least busy person outside of the board. Not true. Who also has no life.

[00:12:08] Who also has no life, and therefore, the leadership of the Board of Ed is determined appropriately for another two years. Thanks everybody, and welcome to Dr. Anderson. Good morning, we know you had a little bit of trouble getting into the building, we're happy to have you here, and you still have the honeymoon glow, so welcome and congrats and best wishes and all that, happy to have you.

[00:12:36] All right, a quick note on the agenda, we will defer item H at the request of staff, we'll move that to the September agenda. First item then is the approval of the minutes from the June 16 and 17 meetings of the board.

[00:12:53] Is there a motion to approve the minutes or to amend? - Mr. President, I move that the minutes of the June 17th meeting be approved. - Okay, thank you. Is there a second?

[00:13:09] - Second. - Thank you, Ms. Davis-Vaught. Oh, excuse me, Dr. Davis-Vaught, all in favor signify by saying aye. - Aye. - Any opposed? Yep, any opposed? Okay, as I said before, are pleased to have people to comment in public. As always, we will continue to accept written public comment to the Board's email inbox, boe@doe.virginia.gov. Speakers will be recognized in the order in which the request was received. Speakers must limit their remarks to three minutes each. When your time is up, please close your remarks promptly. We ask that you provide your

[00:13:47] name and affiliation at the beginning of your remarks. That's really for the minutes. you may provide copies of your comments you can email a copy of your comments to emily webb director of board

relations after you finish speaking uh i will say it is the habit of this board not to respond uh to public comment at the meeting however you know all people who comment are directed to appropriate you know for appropriate staff response so you can't expect a response

[00:14:17] so uh first reverend robin mines thank you and thank you for being with us thank you greetings my name is reverend robin mines i'm a graduate of richmond public schools an air force veteran a community leader a pastor and the founder of the richmond community coalition i am speaking today on behalf of a coalition of parents community members and stakeholders in richmond public schools to express serious concern with the conduct of the

[00:14:57] Richmond school board over the past six months the board majority has acted in ways contrary to accepted standards of leadership and governance it also has failed to prioritize its primary mission improving educational outcomes for students at a time when many Richmond students have experienced learning loss and other severe challenges related to the pandemic it is our belief that the failure of the school board to meet accepted standards of governance at both the procedural and substantial level is so severe that they mandate a review and possible correction

[00:15:33] action corrective action by the state board we have organized this letter into five crucial concerns failure to follow norms of good governance and proper procedure secondly rejecting professional advice of the school administration and setting unrealistic expectations ignoring community input failing to prioritize attention to reopening, needlessly delaying construction of badly needed new facilities. Our concerns result primarily from the way the Richmond School Board has, in recent months, handled the matter of school construction policy. But we are concerned about

[00:16:12] the broader implications of this pattern of behavior and decision making for the remainder of the current board's elected term. We are counting on you to put our children first. Thank you for your time thank you uh tisha irby good morning and welcome good morning do you hear me still with the mask yes okay i'm a little nervous but sorry um my name is tisha irby i'm a graduate

[00:16:48] of georgewood high school class of 2007. i'm a parent of five boys four of whom are rps students i am going to be reading our concerns with the school board failure to follow norms of good governancy and proper proceedings on april 12 2021 the board of men on gender men meaning to consider a motion from the school board represent kenya gibson for the board to assume full responsibility for construction of a new george with rather than continue to partner with the city of richmond on cert on certain procurement or and project management

[00:17:27] function to state open meeting laws and freedom of information act requirement this motion was not posted or distributed publicly per to the meeting as a result there was no public notice of or opportunity to comment on this motion in advance of the school board vote this sick this signature policy shift and department from recent practice in richmond was then adopted by a five to four vote citizens were denied their right to write to weigh in on the change because of the late addition

[00:18:03] this action direct the rps administration to create a new school construction divide division despite the fact that rps fy 2022 budget submitted two months earlier did not account for these positions the religion sorry the resolution was induct and passed despite the city of richmond plan to release the rfp for a new georgia school period is identified by the school board as

[00:18:34] as its top prescription product sorry the city went ahead and released the rfp anyway with the hopes that it's doing so the school board will come to a compromise and unlimited leverage the city procurement team instead of creating an expensive and redundant department thank you thank you uh christopher irby good morning my name is christopher irby ii i'm a rising eighth

[00:19:13] grader at river city middle school in richmond public schools and i'm going to share our concerns about how the rps school board has rejected the professional advice of the rps administration while setting a realistic and arbitrary expression for the rps leaders at april 12 rps school board meeting. RPS Superintendent Jason Carrings clearly stated that in the passing of this construction resolution, the board was making a mistake and estimated that schools building schools would delay construction of a new George WIF school by three years, which the WIF community did not deserve. He also explained that the assumption of procurement and construction management

[00:19:52] responsibilities could distract his administration from more urgent work to resume in-person learning and launch summer school the board and ignored his input on july 19 2021 the school board adopted a resolution directing the rps administration to issue a new request for proposals for the design of george web high school by august 31st 2021 despite the fact that rps does not have appropriate staff to undertake such work at this time that the city of george i mean the city of

[00:20:28] richmond currently has an outstanding rfp for the design of george wick and the many other urgent tasks facing rps administration prior to august 31st mr karen's mr camis warned that something will fall through the cracks with his unrelated directive again by a five to four vote this professional advice was ignored and the resolution was adapted i mean addition additionally the resolution was introduced discussed and voted on in one meeting while providing any opportunity for

[00:21:02] public comment thank you teresa kennedy good morning my name is teresa kennedy and i'm a mother of two boys both of whom are rps students and i will be discussing our concerns with the way that the rps school board has ignored community input the richmond public school board has also ignored

[00:21:38] the input of other stakeholders in the broader community this may the richmond city mayor and city council leadership sent the school board a letter proposing a new cooperation agreement to follow the construction of george with to move forward on time or sorry to allow the construction of george with to move forward on time with existing resources and staff while rps worked on building its own internal capacity to handle a project of this scale to date the school board has not issued a response to the May letter from the city of Richmond nor have they responded to an

[00:22:13] additional letter sent in June when the mayor explained he would like to work with the schools on procurement numerous community members submitted public comment at meetings in April May and June pertaining to the George with matter but no formal solicitation of the public views took place until the school board scheduled a special community meeting on July 13th 2021 at at George Wythe High School.

[00:22:39] At this meeting, approximately three dozen community members, including students, parents, staff, and alumni of George Wythe High School, as well as numerous community leaders spoke. Every single speaker spoke in favor of the school board reaching an agreement with the city to build a new George Wythe.

[00:23:01] Not one speaker supported the school board's actions. One student speaker complained during their comments school board members appeared not to be listening to her comments but were instead paying attention to their phone one member got up and left the room and another member left the stage during the same speaker's comments the day following the meeting the school board member who left the meeting posted on social media that she had been personally mistreated by the public comments and criticized a news story about the meeting as propaganda once again community members wrote to

[00:23:36] the school board public comments wrote the school board public comments to be read at this past monday july 19th regular business meeting and once again there was not one comment at monday's meeting that supported the school wills schools build schools resolution from april 1st also at monday's meeting the school board then acted to move forward with planning a smaller george width of just 1600 students as opposed to the 2000 recommended by the administration this generationally

[00:24:10] impact important decision was made without any public input whatsoever or any serious weighing of the impact and ripple effects of this decision community members agree with the rps administration's assessment that strong student growth in the south side of richmond as well as the fact that some Southside students are being bused now to high schools north of the James River make planning for the larger school far more appropriate. In short, the school board moved in the opposite direction of public input without providing clearly documented rationale or soliciting

[00:24:47] meaningful public or professional input on the policy changes it enacted. And then our next reader jenny agamo isn't here she was unable to make it in time can i submit her comments do you want me to read them too or no actually i'm okay if you read them i think that's fine thank you for the offer all right pretend i'm jenny agamo good morning my name is jenny agamo i'm a mom of four girls two of whom are class of 21 graduates from rps and two more who are rps students i'm going to share our concerns about the ways the rps school board has needlessly delayed the construction of

[00:25:26] of the new George Wythe High School and how they have failed to prioritize attention to reopening. First, this is how we believe the RPS School Board has needlessly delayed the construction of a new George Wythe High School. The sum result of the School Board's actions has been a delay in the construction of the new George Wythe.

[00:25:44] The current George Wythe building is universally recognized as substandard and Wythe is the lowest performing school in the city and among the lowest in the Commonwealth of Virginia as measured by on-time graduation rates, 50% in 2020. Over 90% of students at the school are black and Latino.

[00:26:03] Community members believe the delay of a new school building is inconsistent with the priority of lifting academic achievement for all students and moving all students to all schools to full accreditation as quickly as possible. In the July 13th public meeting, this is Jenny Agamo who just arrived, Community members provided testimony and physical evidence of the dilapidated and decrepit conditions at George Wythe currently.

[00:26:29] The decisions of the school board will extend, likely by years, the length of time RPS students must attend this expired facility. Our reading of RPS's MOU with the VOE also suggests that many steps in the construction process, if handled directly by RPS, may require state review leading to further delays and expenses in the construction process.

[00:26:56] Our research... Oh, is that... - No, you're fine. - Okay. - We're trying to handle the feedback on the call. - Okay. - Let's keep going. - Our research has not yet yielded any recent examples of other school systems under an MOU with VDOE, building new schools on their own.

[00:27:13] Next, this is how we believe the RPS School Board has failed to prioritize attention to reopening. The decision to mandate that RPS administration create as quickly as possible a new construction division and hire the skilled procurement personnel required to oversee school construction also creates a massive distraction from the urgent work of helping Richmond schools reopen safely. In-person education in Richmond was extremely limited in 2021 and the vast majority of RPS students have been in virtual

[00:27:48] learning since March 2020 these students will need extra support and the district needs a plan to help these students overcome learning loss as well as any additional non-academic needs like mental health support and trauma counseling so that the pandemic does not lead to permanent setbacks in academic achievement setbacks which would further delay the achievement of full accreditation for all Richmond Public Schools we believe it is deeply inappropriate and irresponsible for the rps school board to spend time and resources expanding the rps administration's scope of responsibility when it has not demonstrated excellence in exercising

[00:28:28] its current responsibilities and when many children are in urgent need of additional support right now as noted above the july 19th resolution places extraordinary pressure on the superintendent at a time when full attention should be executing the many moving parts should be on executing the many moving parts involved in reopening a system 25 000 students during a pandemic that is still ongoing um and then just note that the also they failed to approve the federal stimulus dollars

[00:29:02] um thank you mr gamo and thank you miss kennedy um miss williams please lakeisha williams good - Good morning.

[00:29:22] My name is Larkeesha Williams, and I am a teacher and a parent of four children of RPS. I have been a teacher for 13 years. I'm gonna share our request with you of the Board of Education. We have deeply concerns and setbacks of actions, which we believe are very harmful to students of Richmond Public Schools in specifics, harmful of the current and future students of George Wilf.

[00:29:48] We write to alert the Board of Education these concerns and request that you examine these matters thoroughly as the authority ultimately response for the Richmond Public Education and the Commonwealth of Virginia. Specifically, we ask that you mandate by the terms of the 2017 MOU. With Richmond Public Schools, DOE, and the staff review will consider denying approval of any expenses in recurrent to RPS using state or federal dollars as a construction process to oppose the investment of the

[00:30:25] instructional needs we also ask that the decision-making process which have led to the current rps board policies be examined on governance perspectives that has been presented one member of the rps board has gone so far to assert that the original public schools are wholly separate from the city of richmond even though the city and the city taxpayers fund over half of the school's budget even though the school board is legally mandated to respond to the requirements of the

[00:31:00] commonwealth of virginia we are concerned that this is a mistake mistake in view the local board school boards will hold the announcement unit will impede on the process in richmond including common sense collaboration and resources shared with the city and that the effort will take control over

everything everything related to schools with the school board losing their prime focus of the objective and responsibility of improving the academic process and outcomes

[00:31:35] of our richmond children finally we ask that the board of education review the impact of rps administration staff and leadership time being devoted to the issue instead of planning for the 2021-2022 school year and identifying and meeting the needs of children returning to in-person learning due to the pandemic we do not mistake this request lightly at all we value the leadership of our school board but we believe the school board must follow the government's procedures

[00:32:13] in and that the richmond and that richmond is specific obligations to focus with the intentions on improving academic performance that resent the actions of richmond public school board that do not appear to respect the intent focus of our children thank you thank you very much uh charles willis congratulations uncle dan that's an inside joke y'all don't don't worry about

[00:32:47] that that's an inside joke uh and congratulations madam vice president as well as president board members thank you so much i do apologize i do not have a reading statement i shared with uh one of your staff members that going forward i would make sure that i would have a written statement but i do want to share that even if i did have a written statement i think at this point it needs to come directly from the heart one of the things that i've watched each and every one of you all since you've been sitting here listening to the comments about the state of richmond public schools and that's what i come to this morning to share with you

[00:33:23] i have not seen you turn away from our comments i have not seen you drink anything i have not seen you on your phones i have not seen you get up and go to the restroom and that's because i believe that all of you all value the opportunity that we as citizens and parents and children have come this far because of the concerns we have for richmond public schools you've heard a lot of comments about george with and i share with you that our children must be first not power and not politics and there are board members and i'm going to call them out specifically who they are because there are comments that have been mentioned if you've seen in the media about the

[00:33:59] school board but i share with you today it is not the school board as a whole these five individuals have uh positioned themselves to pretty much uh present themselves in a way that they have pretty much taken over the operations and the directions of the school board and have just plainly ignored the concerns of the communities five board members is none other than the vice chair of mr jonathan young miss kenya gibson miss stephanie rizzi miss mariah white and dr chandra harris muhammad

[00:34:36] we have spoke with them individually i've reached out to some of them individually and said how can we make this work how can we get this done and it's not only about the faith of george whip high school, but also Woodville and also the technical center that we talked about. And then it goes even further because if you do this to one, you'll do it to all. So the faith of John Marshall that is soon to be rebuilt and Armstrong, which is in the building of John F. Kennedy. All of those things, they matter to us. But what's most important to me, I want to share with you all, and we are at the mercy of the board. There are some folks that figured if they get five votes, they don't have to

[00:35:14] say nothing. They don't have to do nothing, and they can do what they want to do. But we believe that there's a higher power, and that higher power, that higher authority sits with this body right today. So we are asking you all that you all would come together in some form or fashion and hold Richmond Public Schools accountable to us, the citizens, the parents, the voters. I can tell you that they sit

and listen just like you all are doing now. But I believe strongly in my heart that you all are going to go into a closed session or a meeting and you're going to discuss what we are talking about now and you're going to come

[00:35:51] back to us and say we we either want to hear more we're going to come out of these seats and go into the community we want to hear more from the community board members we don't want to hear from you we want to hear from the community we have five board members that say we don't want to hear from you we're listening but we don't want to hear from you and the young folks i say in the closing of this our young teenagers today have words that they have their own language one of me is you don't feel me and they don't mean touch them don't put your hands on them that means you don't understand what they're going through in their hearts another one they say is you in the way and when a young teenager tell you you're in the way that means you you're doing something that is out of

[00:36:31] norm and they want you out of the way and they normally do things to get you out of the way unfortunately a lot of that you've seen that comes from our young homicides I close with this the other is you're doing too much our original five board members are doing too much and that too much is too much for us the citizens and we need them to listen thank you so much for the opportunity to speak thank you all for being here is there anybody else although we did take the list is there anybody else who'd like to address the board for me please come on forward and it's okay state your name and any affiliation

[00:37:05] you have i'm sorry i emailed late yesterday that's okay no we do this routinely i'm sorry you didn't make the list but we're happy to have you um my name is la barbara jones i'm a george with alumni i graduated in 99. um i am a former i am a parent of a former student i have a middle school student who is slated to go to george with i work at george with as the attendance of person and i live in the community they walk past my house all the time so that's the attendance lately house so i've watched this school over amount of years it was slated to be rebuilt when i was in school

[00:37:45] 1997. Another school, which is 20 years younger than George Wyft, 15 to 20 years younger, had a problem in the gym. Not only did they fix it, they knocked down the whole school and rebuilt it because they were in a middle-class neighborhood. Brown students started going to that school.

[00:38:04] They rezoned it and put those brown students in George Wyft in a failing school. This is not becoming just an issue of safety in the building. This is a social justice issue. This is a human rights issue when you have mouse feces on the students desk every day mice sitting on a on a it's infested you can hear them as you sit in your office going across the ceiling you cannot get rid of them because it is and feces in the ceiling so even if you kill the ones that's there

[00:38:39] the scent brings more in we have had several janitors get cancer we have had several teachers die they requested to leave that school for years because they said they had not been sick in any other school till they came to george will and we lost a loyal teacher because they finally moved her to hug and that machine it was already too late we have students that need help but you cannot focus on teaching them or getting them to come to school if their school looks like where they come

[00:39:14] from because school is supposed to be a safe haven so if you have kids coming from lower income housing where they are shooting and killing where it is dirty where it is unclean and then they come in a building to see the same thing how can we do anything how can we stand there and say it's okay it's not okay i have seen it go on for decades and decades this is becoming more than just we need a new building we need a new mindset we need empathy we need people who don't have

[00:39:49] backhand agendas we need people with less pride on the school board we need people with less egos we need people who actually care about someone other than their career future it is important and imperative the school will not make it to 2027 they want to start building in 2025 it will not make it if george with if you say you are only as great as your weakest link and if george with is

[00:40:20] the weakest link and it has mold rats roaches filth cracks in the building leaks in the ceiling Then what does that say about Virginia? VDOE. What does that say about RPS? What does that say about us? We will never meet the standards given to us for SOLs. We will never meet the standards given to us for VDOE. Because when I was in school, it was struggling, but at least it was somewhat of a safe haven. And we thought it was going to get better. Now there is nothing in

[00:40:58] foresight for us. Every time they're supposed to rebuild, they were supposed to rebuild in 2018, they put us on the back burner. They rezone and put more kids and poverty into that school. This is not just for a building. This is for everything. This is a risk that you have to take to help us. We are begging you. I cannot watch this anymore. Thank you. Thank you. Is there

[00:41:33] anybody else you'd like to speak, even though they didn't get on the signup list? If not, I mean, although we typically don't comment, I will say this. There are a number of us on this board who you know live and work in this area and are clearly very familiar you know certainly with the public reporting with what's going on and you know i will tell you uh how much i appreciate uh the clarity of your presentation as you know well as the organization of the presentation and the fact that you all took the time to be here today um you know i think as at least one of the speakers

[00:42:09] noted, you know, our control of local matters is, you know, peculiarly limited, right? I mean, the Commonwealth setup is that locals do control their, you know, the divisions. You know, that being said, you know, I think the board will talk a little bit at some point about the issues because Richmond is, as also pointed out by one of the speakers, a jurisdiction under MOU. And, you know, we do have, you know, certain rights to look, which is not the same as saying we have governance

[00:42:45] rights. I don't want to mislead anybody or to suggest we have the ability to have governance rights. We don't, but we do have certain things that we're entitled to do under the MOU, and there will be some conversations about what we think would be appropriate. So, I don't want you to think that we can snap our fingers and change things because we can't. On the other hand, I don't want you to walk away thinking we didn't listen to you because we did. And, you know, I hope that satisfactory to all of you and again thank you for taking the time to be here and you know seriously thank you for being so well organized about it and not

[00:43:22] just being duplicative speaker after speaker it was a well very well done presentation so thank you all now you are welcome to stay for the rest of our meeting or if you want to take this time to sort of you know exit you're welcome and don't have to feel rude about doing that thank you okay move on to the

[00:43:59] consent agenda, items A through D. Is there anybody who wants to pull any item from the consent agenda or is there a motion to approve the agenda as drafted? Motion to approve the agenda as drafted. Thank you, Dr. Duran. Is there a second? Second. Thank you, Dr. Wilson. Any discussions? See none. All in favor? Aye. Aye. Aye. I was waiting for it, Dr. Davis-Vaught, so that's good. Thank you. All right, item E, final review for consent to the establishment of

[00:44:32] joint operated school region 7 virtual academy mr bowling good morning president gecker dr wilson dr lane members of the board item e provides for final review the formal request for consent to establish excuse me a joint operated school in virginia as required by 22.1-26 of the code of virginia this section of the code requires the board of education's consent when two or more school boards wish to establish a joint or regional school or program since first review

[00:45:05] for additional schools have in superintendents region 7 have joined the original 13 school division partners to create the region 7 virtual academies that is that is seeking the consent to establish the joint operator program today the superintendent of public construction recommends that the board provide consent to establish the region 7 virtual academy is the joint operated program. The Academy is represented on the phone by Dr. Keith Parajan, Superintendent of Bristol City Public Schools, Dr. Robert Graham, Superintendent of Radford

[00:45:40] City Public Schools, and Ms. Caitlin Cosme, Executive Director of the Region 7 Virtual Academy and are available to answer questions that you may have. Thank you. Are there any questions from board members? We've heard the presentations before. I think we got some supplemental materials in the interim. If not, gentlemen, thank you for being on the phone with us, or more than gentleman, gentleman and lady perhaps, for being on the phone with us. However, I don't see any questions from the board. Is there a motion to approve this? So moved, President Gecker.

[00:46:18] Thank you, Dr. Wilson. Is there a second? Thank you, Dr. Duran. All those in favor signify by saying aye. Aye. Waiting for Dr. Davis-Vaught. This is an item, President Gecker, which I must refuse. Oh, that's right. Thank you. Motion passes thank you thank you thanks everybody thank you item f final review of revisions to model

[00:46:55] guidance for positive and preventative code of student conduct policy and alternatives to suspension or perhaps not all right we'll move on to item g final review of revised regulation for licensed child daycare centers transferring from the board of social services to the board of education uh ms conway okay no big deal good morning president gecker vice president wilson

[00:47:32] members of of the board uh this is our last step in moving over you've heard me say that before but i promise unless we uncover something else but this is our last step in moving all of the regulations over as is um and as you'll remember one of the commitments we made when we uh in partnership with the General Assembly established the unification legislation is that we would move everything over as is create the early childhood advisory committee and then revisit licensing and subsidy regulations this is one piece

[00:48:08] that was literally in motion when you when you all approve the as is move over a few months ago so it's a small piece of regulation that was good dates back started this work started in 2016 at the Department of Social Services it went through full review under the Board of Social Services full public comment and then was finally approved just after we moved over the body of regulations so what you're doing today is just agreeing to move over this last piece it pertains to child day centers and it is just bringing them in alignment with the federal reauthorization which again passed in 2015 so things like making

[00:48:47] sure it's clear that they all have to have certain expectations around training and orientation one of the things that the federal government requires now is the establishment of group size so you have ratios in terms of teacher-child ratios and then it says how what's the maximum number you can have in

any classroom or space so again just a set of things that Virginia put into effect as a result of the federal law and this is the last piece that the reason we didn't bring to three months ago is because it was still being going through the full public comment over at the Board of Social Services okay thank

[00:49:22] Thank you. I still think of you as chief readiness officer, by the way. I'm not going to get used to the new title, but so soon. All right. Any questions for Deputy Superintendent of Early Childhood Education, Conway? Or it's mighty quiet this month.

[00:49:41] We will take this, because the as-is work is much easier than the to-come work. Okay. Is there a motion then to adopt item G? So moved, President Gecker. Thank you, Dr. Wilson. Is there a second? Second. Thank you.

[00:49:58] Second. Dr. Anderson. No discussion. All in favor signify by saying aye. Aye. Thank you. Aye. Thank you. Okay. Is Dr. Hollins here yet?

[00:50:15] Not yet. Okay. Item I. First review of proposed revisions to the guidelines for locally awarded verified credits to allow for the use of performance assessments to verify credits in history and social science. Ms. Loving Ryder and Mr. Bolling.

[00:50:33] Good morning again. Good morning. Item I outlines proposed revisions to the standards of accreditation guidance, the standards of accreditation or SOA guidance document pertaining to awarding locally verified credits. The revisions allow for the use of performance assessments to verify credits in history and social science and address the language in the 2020 and 2021 General Assembly's Appropriation Act that adds, quote, successful completion of assessments that include state-developed performance tasks scored locally

[00:51:10] in accordance with board guidelines using state-developed rubrics, end quote, as an option for earning verified credit in history and social science. These amendments to the SOA guidance document will provide guidance for local school divisions that exercise the option of using state developed performance tasks in conjunction with other local assessments to determine if a student has earned locally awarded verified credit in history and social science i'll now turn it over to michelle loving rider to walk you through the proposed revisions good morning mr gecko president

[00:51:46] members of the board and dr lane as michael mentioned what we're bringing you to today is revisions to the guidelines for awarding locally awarded verified credits and these revisions are in response to the appropriations act language as michael noted that does provide the opportunity for the award of verified credits by the use of performance assessments in history what we're bringing you today is really patterned after the guidelines you provided to school divisions during the pandemic in the emergency guidelines for the use of performance assessments

[00:52:24] to for a locally awarded verified credit the guidelines themselves are in attachment b that's the strike through an underlined version, and then there's a clean version in attachment C. I'm going to go over the version in attachment B so that you can see the changes.

[00:52:43] But before we do that, I wanted to acknowledge the wealth of information that is included in attachment A. This details all of the support that the department has provided to school divisions since 2015 in the use of performance assessments in the area of history.

[00:53:03] And I'd also like to acknowledge the work of Kristonya Brown, the coordinator of history in the Department of Learning. She's in the audience today. And also the work of Holly Cook, who's the performance assessment coordinator in the division of student assessment.

[00:53:20] There are many other people who've been involved in this process, but Kristonya and Holly have really led the work. So we wanted to acknowledge their efforts in shepherding this through the work with school divisions. So I'll turn now to attachment B.

[00:53:37] This is the revisions to the guidelines for locally awarded verified credit. These guidelines are included in a larger document called the SOA Guidance Document. This fairly extensive document really includes all of the guidelines that deal with the standards of accrediting schools.

[00:53:57] So in attachment B, if you want to follow along, the changes really begin on page two. You know that we've had guidelines for awarding locally awarded verified credit for some time. And what we have done in this change is to add an option two.

[00:54:16] And this really is consistent with the emergency guidelines that you approved during the pandemic. So option two is only applicable to history. And it states that to get a locally awarded verified credit in history, the student must pass the course and then demonstrate mastery of the content of that course through evidence. That evidence must include performance tasks that have been developed by the state, so state-developed performance tasks. Additionally,

[00:54:52] the student responses to those tasks must be scored using the state-developed rubric, So state-developed tasks, state-developed rubrics, and then finally the revision states that any locally awarded verified credit awarded under this option would not count towards the cap that is typically in place for locally awarded verified credits.

[00:55:20] As you all are well aware, under the provisions of the locally awarded verified credit statement the soa school divisions must develop a process for reviewing the evidence when this occurs and the appeals process for option one remains the same but for option two again there would be a local panel convened it would have to be at least three educators who would review the evidence and there could be a different panel for each school or one for the division overall

[00:55:54] and it is important to note that the student's teacher of record cannot sit on that particular panel the local review panel would review the evidence and the evidence would have to contain at least three of the four performance tasks that are available for that history course each of the history courses are divided into four eras and there is a task for each era so three of those four tasks must be evident in the evidence and then additionally there would be other

[00:56:29] local assessments that would cover the other content so a collection of evidence that really would cover all of the content but that must include three of the four available performance tasks and then as is the case with the current option one the local the panel would either recommend awarding the verified credit or recommend additional evidence or deny the request there is also additional guidelines included in this document about how the performance task would be used at the bottom of page three it talks about the state developed tasks we have

[00:57:09] currently tasks in place for virginia and u.s history that have been developed in collaboration with field and experts in the area staff at the department are currently working on tasks for the other history courses world history one world history two and world geography and that work is is going on this

summer there's also a statement that the standards of learning for the course must be covered either through the performance task or through other evidence and then again a statement that reiterates that the tasks must be state developed this

[00:57:45] This is to comply with the requirement in the appropriations language that the task used must be state-developed and that the state-developed rubric must be used. There's also a statement at the bottom that provides guidance about scoring.

[00:58:00] It makes it clear that the best practice is the student's teacher would not participate in the scoring, but that there is an option that for two of the three tasks used, the of record could be a score on page five there's a requirement for an annual notification if a school division wishes to pursue this option and then they would have to provide a plan and then lastly we would intend to continue our practice of using desk reviews in this process as Michael and I shared with you

[00:58:38] last month and we've been talking about local alternative assessments from the lower grade history and writing, we talked about the value of those desk reviews. It really is a way of seeing what school divisions are doing, a way to identify best practices that we can share, and also a way in which we can identify areas where additional support might be needed.

[00:59:03] So Mr. Gecker, the Superintendent of Public Instructions recommends that you accept this revision to the SOA guidance document on first review and Michael and I would be happy to answer any questions and Kristania and Holly are our backup if there are questions that we can't answer.

[00:59:20] - Okay, so we have the complete A team here with us. Thank you. Any questions by board members? Yeah, Dr. Wilson. - Thank you, Ms. Lovingrider and Mr. Bolin. Thank you very much. So just one quick question.

[00:59:36] Remind us about the desk review process to ensure that we have, in general, that we have a wide perspective of what's going on across the Commonwealth as opposed to individual divisions? - So typically we take a sample and so we usually use 24 school divisions, three from each region, and we attempt to select rural, urban, suburban, and so on.

[01:00:01] And then typically there would be a different group the following year. Sometimes, as we shared last month, we do a division two years in a row to get sort of a sense of progress over time.

[01:00:17] And if we have more staff, we could do more, but right now it's 24 divisions. - Any other questions? Dr. Durant. - No question, just wanna comment and thank you all for the work that you've done in this area. I hope that we will be able to gather the data and continue to tell our story so that eventually we can go beyond just history, social science to other areas where I do believe locally and we've talked about it too in some of our discussions and formally on the so innovation committee we had a lot of discussions around the power behind um performance-based assessments and so um i just want to encourage uh now that we are moving in this way in the area of history

[01:00:57] and social science how do we capture and maybe some comments from how we might capture uh what this is and the data and how it's being used in a meaningful way even following up when dr wilson just said how we're using the reviews in that manner to be able to show that this actually is going to have a positive impact from teachers and students, and how do we even involve their voice in this in the qualitative side of what we're looking at, as well as quantitatively seeing what we're doing.

[01:01:22] So any comment on that, but really just want to thank you for your work and really encourage us to move forward as best we can in the area of performance-based assessments. And a lot of that is going to be educating our General Assembly members to understand this as well in a way how it's meaningful. I think that over time we've looked at assessments and we've known that when we've tried to quantify an assessment through a multiple choice or some more SOLs, you know, going way back, I remember the discussions about how that was so important to get the multiple choice and have that very clear and not have any sense of subjectivity.

[01:01:57] And people were afraid of just looking at performance-based assessments because of the subjectivity that might be involved. And that was a whole pushback, if you might remember, on the ESL Innovation Committee, those conversations we had. But this is an opportunity now for us to show that, yes, assessment can still be done in this way and actually can be done in a very powerful way to inform instruction regularly and more differentiated for students and also meaningful for students.

[01:02:21] Because what I have seen for students who've engaged with performance assessments, they really, really are bought into and get excited about their learning and are proud to showcase what they have accomplished and what they've learned and what they've mastered in that area so isn't that what we want it to be all about right our students getting excited about their learning not as excited about taking an SOL assessment but I just want to encourage us to do that and would love any comments you have on what you might be thinking about how we can use this data to help us on that charge and you know very well as you were part of this innovation committee conversation so many years ago but let's not let that

[01:02:56] work die with this thank you a couple of thoughts I think one of the values of our current situation with history is that we do have the state developed tasks so there's some commonality in what a student in Bristol and a student in Acomac would respond to there's also the state developed rubrics so there's some commonality in the way in which the students work would be scored and one thing I didn't mention is there's ongoing work to create anchor samples

[01:03:32] that go with those rubrics and dr. Wilson I know is very familiar with that process from her work with the writing assessment over time but it really is those anchor papers that help to define what is expected in the rubric I know that sometimes the desk reviews seem like they are punitive or accountability driven but it really is those desk reviews that has helped us to move forward with this project we requested documents from the school divisions who are selected but staff also do extensive interviews with each of the selected

[01:04:11] divisions and then they take that information and create webinars that are then shared with all school divisions so it's a way of identifying you know what works and sharing it but it's also a way to help us move forward i think department staff for the most part are very committed to a continuous improvement model and this is a way to help us continue to move you know writing was the first uh area we we did this with we certainly learned a lot from writing but um you know history is very different while we focus on the history skills

[01:04:49] There's also content in history that must be covered, and Christiana is very adamant that one of the things in the rubric is accuracy of content. So, you know, when we move to history, it really is that balance between the history skills where we want students to understand, you know, different sources and the need to use evidence to support their arguments, but there's also making sure that they have that accuracy of content.

[01:05:16] So, Dr. Duran, I think that we have learned a lot and I think, you know, we are trying to move forward with using that content as we move forward. Michael, I don't know if you have anything to add. Michael Duran: Thank you. Dr. Lane, do you have any thoughts on that? I know you also, I think you came to the very last SLA Innovation Committee that we had and you talked about your vision and some of this area, so I would love any of your thoughts around how this could help us in that path and the journey we're on.

[01:05:41] Michael Duran: Certainly, one of the things that I've heard pretty frequently is that we need to show that we've built the capacity before there will even be discussions at the GA about any expansion. And to be honest, when we look at some of the legislation that was passed this year, we saw some movement in a positive direction on authentic assessment, and then we saw some increasing of more traditional assessment. And so I think that this project, with your approval the next time you meet on this is essential to us being able to make the case that our school divisions are ready.

[01:06:20] And I think that when we do that, it opens a whole new world of possibilities. I actually think that performance assessment isn't the only way to go either, though. Shelley and I have talked at length about potentially some combination assessments. Could you fuse the reading and writing assessments together?

[01:06:37] Could you fuse some reading, writing, and history and social sciences together? and so it it may not be just this but i think this opens the door to new exploration thank you appreciate that dr man yeah it's very interesting conversation just really curious just nationally are there other states that are using performance-based strategies to complement their assessment endeavors are we on the bleeding edge the cutting edge the frontier just a very very interesting conversation. There are other states across the country

[01:07:13] who are using performance assessments. New Hampshire is probably the one you hear the most about. So there are other states. I'm not aware of other states that are using performance assessments in history to the extent we are trying to, but that's certainly something we can look into and get back to you. An important piece of context there is because Because history is not mandated by the federal government, every state does not assess in history.

[01:07:42] And so it's one of the reasons that we think that this is an area for us to begin innovating, because if we want to get into the other subject areas, not only do we have to talk with the General Assembly about some flexibility, we'd also have to talk with the federal government. Anybody else?

[01:07:58] Yes. Ms. Halton. If I may, I was going to raise a matter I just wanted to comment on in our discussion of current issues, but I'm going to stick it in here because I think it's relevant and and I'd love to have Kristania be in the audience.

[01:08:14] First, thank you for your wonderful work. In addition to what we've been talking about, the work to incorporate the, I've read your report on African-American history education and the work you've done to incorporate the recommendations from the Governor's Commission on African-American history, and on history education is really important.

[01:08:39] And I know it's challenging in your wrestling with a lot of competing interests, but the importance of telling our story accurately and recognizing that we haven't told it accurately in the past and that now we need to is so important.

[01:08:57] And in that vein, I just want to raise up for you, and for everybody, a remarkable man who passed away a few weeks ago, Bill Robertson, who was my father's advisor in his governor's office back in 1970, and has actually written a memoir just before, finished his memoir just before he passed, and it will be coming out from UVA Press later this year or early next year, and I'm going to make sure you get an advance copy as soon as possible.

[01:09:31] When my dad was elected governor in 1969, he announced in his inaugural address in January of 1970 that he wanted to initiate an aristocracy of ability regardless of race, color, or creed, and that seems so sort of normal now, but in 1970 that was the end of the age of defiance of massive resistance in a symbolic way, at least. And part of what he promised was that he was going to integrate state government. And he started by naming Bill Robertson to his leadership team. Bill was a principal in a Roanoke City public school and had done

[01:10:08] great work there in various community endeavors. And dad asked him to come serve as the first American in a leadership role in state government and charged him, among other things, with helping integrate state government. He, in this memoir, tells some of those amazing stories including integrating the state police. The first African American members on the state police were there because of Bill Robertson's doggedness in recruiting candidates and convincing them to be willing to apply, shepherding them through, passing all the qualifying exams,

[01:10:44] and then despite passing through all the qualifying exams, having to, shall we say, encourage a reluctant bureaucracy to then take advantage of their talents, and then proceeding to do that in every other state agency. He said in his memoir, he says, well, they had never seen anyone like me in state government, so he became something of a celebrity. He was speaking both within his state government role and beyond publicly in all kinds of ways.

[01:11:17] And I won't go on, but went on to serve in the Peace Corps. He was passionate about his work with the JCs, the supporting camps for students with disabilities throughout his life, remained a family friend throughout his life. And I raise his story up as an example of one of the many that we need to raise up in all kinds of ways as we as we rethink the story of our past thank you no question no that was all all comment the question is just how quickly can i

[01:11:52] get you that to that memoir and i'll i'll i'll follow up separately on that okay thank you all right uh thank you all very much i will board is happy to accept this on first review thank you thank you all right we'll go back now to item f uh final review of revisions to model guidance for positive and preventative code of student conduct policy and alternatives to suspension dr hollands good morning i apologize profusely for my delay i find it ironic that i managed to be on time for a year and a half of distance meetings and in another location but two floors

[01:12:27] away i was tardy the boat was actually to do this at two o'clock this afternoon by the way just so you know to defer i would be here irregardless so thank you so much for your flexibility and good morning president gecker vice president wilson congratulations board members and dr lane i'm dr sam hollands and it's a pleasure to be with you this morning for the final review of updates to our model guidance for positive and preventative code of conduct student policy and alternatives to suspension um if you will recall we initially reviewed this item at your june meeting and i'm pleased to report that we've taken the time to ensure that there's no additional stakeholder

[01:13:03] feedback or input given the robustness of our initial work with groups on some of these updates which you remember are really due to legislation that's happened over the past two general assembly sessions this item has detailed information within the table to link each of those legislative actions with the updates that we provided in the guide and also while there have been no no substantive edits to the document we did seek to clarify some language on page 11 that maintained the link to research-based practice as well as ensuring that the message was really clear so i do want to bring your attention to that clarification and as always i'm happy to answer any additional questions or concerns and would like to share with you that

[01:13:42] the superintendent's recommendation is for the board to approve the revisions to the model guidance today and i'm happy to answer any questions thank you are there any questions - So Dr. Duran. - So if I heard you correctly, there was no recent public comment and feedback, correct?

[01:14:00] Is that what you said? - Correct, Dr. Duran. There were no additional stakeholder feedback. The board has received none and we also did a circle around with some of our initial stakeholders and folks felt comfortable and felt like they were fully informed regarding the changes and are anxious to begin it in advance of the school year. - Prior public comment, was there any feedback that was received that was not incorporated in here?

[01:14:17] Can you remind us of that? - No, there was not. All of the current changes also reflect of the information if you'll see at the bottom of the table there are some specific instances particularly some of our professional development groups that were incorporated into the editions as well so we were able to take those comments and to fold them into the revisions particularly as many of them address some of the specific items from legislation excellent all right thank you and thank you for your work on this oh my pleasure thank you all for taking the time to review i know it's quite a hefty read but this is a really valuable document for our schools as they really start to pivot to positive school discipline and i'm sure you're aware given the presentation by by Dr. Sale yesterday that this is a really great partnership with our updated data collection measures.

[01:14:57] So we, particularly my Office of Student Services, are very excited for the implementation timeline of this work. - Great, any other questions? Ms. Halton. - Yeah, thank you for all that great work and I really think the final document's gonna be incredibly helpful to the divisions.

[01:15:14] I had one spot and I'm looking for it that you highlighted, you reminded us in your intro notes, the written notes that we had some discussion about page 11, language on page 11, that I'm now trying to get back to.

[01:15:31] And, Secretary Holden, I'm happy to read that aloud or to help you find that if it's . Yes. It might well be helpful to read it aloud just for the sake of everybody else. And I think I have found it. Absolutely. So it's on page 11. It's actually the second paragraph.

[01:15:47] And you'll notice that the content within this paragraph really helps to juxtapose some of the differing social obligations and some of the research we've learned over the last few years, in particular focus on student populations who are coming into the academic and educational environment and where there may be some dissonance between the expectations culturally and within what we've really seen in the past as a formal educational environment.

[01:16:10] So this content specifically speaks to the flexibility and approach of our educators and administrators of being responsive to children's cultural background and students and being able to engage in positive communication and outcomes as a result of any discipline that might occur within the school setting.

[01:16:27] - So if I may, the specific language, and I did have a little potential tweak to it. I understand what you're trying to get at here, but if we're not careful, we could put in language that'll come, that we would, it's hard to get it right, I guess is my point.

[01:16:45] So the current language says that school divisions should recognize the need for addressing the changing demographics of the student population. No argument there. Students from diverse backgrounds are becoming the majority demographic group in U.S. public schools. Got it. This is the sentence that I raise up for consideration. For many students, the rich knowledge set, values, relational styles, and behavioral expectations cultivated and adapted at home under one set of socialization beliefs and practices often do not match up well with those in educational settings so i get what you're trying to get at but it just makes me a little

[01:17:22] uncomfortable and i wonder i mean this maybe is just a very minor tweak i mean a more major tweak would be maybe to think about whether is this language really working for us all together but but do we want to just jettison it but my minor tweak would be instead of saying often do not match up well to just say may not match up well you know because i don't i don't actually have a statistical survey that tells me when folks home expectations match up with school socialization i don't want to presume that they don't and that often to me suggests a presumption that in many

[01:18:01] cases they don't match up so as i say the minor tweak would be just often do not change that to may not i'm happy to make that edit i've actually captured it here i'll make sure it's reflected with emily and i think it's also important to note that this is actually referring specifically to a research-based citation that we use to support that statement so i think that clarification gives the flexibility while also ensuring that folks have a follow-up source to dig into a little bit deeper which focuses on african-american students in particular so i really appreciate that feedback

[01:18:34] anybody else if not thank you dr hollins is there a motion to approve this with the change suggested by uh miss holton so moved to thank you dr duran is there a second thank you dr man uh all those in favor signify by saying hi hi hi thank you dr davis vaut uh that passes thank you so much thank you we are i notice it welcome mr duvall uh we're gonna do a quick five minute really only five

[01:19:09] minute break and then we will be back uh for item j thank you dr davis vaut are you still with us

[01:30:38] One on the phone Barry. That's okay. Yeah. Dr. Davis Vaught, are you with us still on the phone? Yes, sir. Perfect. Thank you. We are going to get going then. We are delighted today to be joined by Barry Duvall, old friend and president and CEO of the Virginia Chamber of Commerce, Dr. Deitra Trent, also old friend, former Secretary of Education and co-chair of the Workforce and Education Blueprint Executive Committee, and Eric Rison, who I actually just

[01:31:17] met today so sorry i can't really have that same appellation uh vice president of public policy and research at the virginia chamber we are really delighted that y'all took the time uh to be with us we know how busy you are uh and barry i'm going to turn the floor to you and you know the board is really

interested in hearing about this important topic so thanks again thank you chairman gecker and uh to the distinguished panel thank you for your public service dr lane thanks for your public service. I think as I was walking in here today, I was thinking about what we all as

[01:31:53] an audience have in common. And we have in common the interest of improving the next generation of Virginians. We have in common the commitment to innovation to do that. And I think we have in common a real commitment to public service. I was visiting just a minute with Dr. Wilson and was reflecting on my time as a mayor of Newport News from 1990 to 96, we actually started the achievable dream program which has become a national model for innovation

[01:32:26] and changing the lives of individuals one student at a time and i told dr wilson that the idea for achievable dream did not come from educators and the idea did not come from politician the idea came from the business community. And I have found in my career the business community's role goes far beyond employing people and far beyond simply producing a product or service.

[01:32:58] But the business community's role rightfully is to invest in the community and invest in the state in which it's located. So the years I spent in local government and then four years the secretary of commerce and trade in virginia helped me um understand power and the influence for good that the business community can have in the commonwealth the last 11 years i've been running the state chamber of commerce and we have put forward two blueprints for virginia closely tied to improving our business climate and we've had a lot of survey work done over the

[01:33:34] years and worked very closely with all the stakeholders from the business community to to the education community, to the health care community, and other important areas. Every four years in Virginia, we have the wisdom or challenge of electing a new governor.

[01:33:51] Every four years in Virginia, we don't get an opportunity to reward the existing governor and give that person a second term. Wisdom of those who constructed our constitution is to have a new governor every 48 months.

[01:34:07] I don't know about your organization, but it's challenging to think about having a new executive in your organization every 48 months. It's challenging for the organization because you begin to set your timeline for planning around 48 month horizons.

[01:34:24] I know that from personal experience having been in a cabinet position for 48 months. But the business community really should think and does think longer term than 48 months. And as I studied best practices around the country, I learned that the most effective way for the business community to make its voice heard is to do so in a nonpartisan way, to endorse ideas and not candidates, and to have a longer-term horizon on issues of competitiveness and present those as a set of ideas.

[01:34:59] So that's where we came up with the original blueprint, presented our first one to Terry McAuliffe after his election, our second one to current Governor Ralph Northam, and then we hope to present our third blueprint to the newly elected governor December 3rd.

[01:35:17] We want you to be part of that blueprint process. We're interested in meeting with all the stakeholders. I've got about a 15-minute presentation that Dr. Trent's going to help me, and she will share some of the results of polling we've done already this year. We've had over 4,000 businesses participate in our polling around the state. And I hope, Mr. Chairman, that we can have a dialogue on issues as well. So if you'll allow me to go through this PowerPoint, I think is it Kevin that's going to be advancing these. We'll go

to the next slide and he'll advance these for me. So just as a reminder for you, the state chamber has a vision to

[01:35:55] be the voice of Virginia business. You may know that we have a goal to be an influential advocacy organization. We are a C6. We do advocate for ideas, and we do lobby the General Assembly. The next slide will show you that our mission is to be nonpartisan. Again, we don't endorse candidates. We endorse ideas, but we are active in the regulatory arena and the legislative arena, and we want it to be a force for good for economic growth in Virginia.

[01:36:26] The next slide will show you a slide of Virginia and every dot represents 25 members. And when I came, we had about 1,000 members. The next slide will show you how we've grown in membership over the last decade. And we're now the largest business organization in Virginia with over 27,000 members, representing about 1.1 million employees through the employer base.

[01:36:50] And that's about 25% of workers in the Commonwealth of Virginia. Every region is recognized and we have a network of about 100 local chambers in Virginia and about 90 of those local chambers have an alliance membership with the state chambers. So I'm here today to represent the state chamber and to be the voice of business and tell you about our blueprint process.

[01:37:12] The next slide will tell you if someone asks me in an elevator what's the goal of the chamber, simply stated it's to be the best state for business, to make sure our reputation is in fact recognized as the best state for business um i i will show you a couple of successes that we've had you've probably seen these the next couple of slides kevin uh we'll go through these quickly uh last week we were announced for the first time in the rankings any state has repeated as the top state for business cnbc came out with this last year and we're very proud of this we can talk more about it later a couple of other rankings if we'll go through these quickly kevin

[01:37:50] Wallet Hub ranked as, number one, best schools in the South, best state for higher education, number two. Another ranking is business facilities. It comes out again, actually, this week, a new ranking. I think we're going to do very well on this. But we're number one in cybersecurity, mostly because of our education and leadership in education.

[01:38:09] And I wanted to point that out. Our business ranking is high as well. Next slide. We'll show you the innovation that is now being ranked by Wallet Hub. We're just in the top five there. Next slide will show you the, let's see, best state for military retirees.

[01:38:28] I told Dan earlier I'm speaking this afternoon to all the base commanders. I'm very proud of this slide. They have an annual gathering of all the military bases and their commanders. So we're very proud of this. Virginia has about 20,000 military veterans that rotate out of the military every year, and about 10,000 stay in Virginia.

[01:38:51] We want that to improve, and we're working with the Department of Veterans Services and a partnership to improve that, and that number continues to go up. But the military, active duty, and their families, and their spouses is a big part of our blueprint process. Next slide.

[01:39:07] We're beginning, as we should have been for a while, to lean in on equity and equality, and I want to mention that there's now rankings coming out around this, even with the best state for business or the top 10. we were seventh last year we were fifth in this area and we can talk more about this later but it is an area that now rankings are beginning to take into consideration next slide a ranking that is not at all

quantitative but purely subjective and that is uh the chief executive magazine does a survey across the country of chief executives and they said just based on your impression right now

[01:39:44] what's the best date for business we were 16th we came in this year 13th i think we should be a top 10 state and that has more to do with the fact that virginia while we have done a lot of marketing for virginia's for lovers and history mountains and beaches back in 09 it was a tough time for governors back then um we stopped marketing virginia for business so we don't run commercials like new york and minnesota and michigan we don't have outside marketing advertising uh so this ranking will go up i think in the future but we really do need some marketing dollars for the

[01:40:18] commonwealth to compete on this ranking next slide just a few slides to talk about technology and virginia has become data center alley if you haven't heard that you will uh yesterday i zoomed with 340 people in northern virginia with the go virginia region and a lot of northern virginia but throughout the commonwealth we have become the hub of the data center alley and it's because of our connectedness and our workforce and business planning the next slide will simply show you the fact that our tech ecosystem is exploding here. And again, workforce, workforce, workforce

[01:40:54] is the driver for this. And we've been very fortunate to have a significant tech ecosystem. Next slide, I think, just indicates the importance of logistics. And logistics, because of our mid-Atlantic location, has become a big economic driver for us. All of this requires a specific level of workforce training, not necessarily four-year degrees.

[01:41:15] but this is a area that is desperate need of more certifications and more training in this area next slide so why blueprint virginia i've alluded to this i think the business community should have its fingerprints on a long-term planning document we try to think four or five years in advance but 10 years is a reasonable time to set some target goals uh the next slide will show you i think a photo of our first blueprint being presented to terry mccullough right after his election in 2013 and work with him on this implementation.

[01:41:50] And our rankings have improved since then. The next slide will show you a photo in front of about 1,000 people we presented to Governor Ralph Northam. And then the next slide will simply talk a little bit about the focus areas of Blueprint Virginia 2025.

[01:42:05] This is the Blueprint we're updating. And Dr. Trent chairs -- or co-chairs, I should say -- of the Workforce and Education Industry Council. And I want to thank her for being here with me today. and i'm going to turn it over to her in just a minute to talk about some of the focus areas in this uh section and some of the results of the surveys that we've had uh in this area but the other areas are important as well and we have goals and objectives in each of those again focusing on endorsing ideas and public policy working with policy makers to implement the blueprint next slide so uh i need to obviously point out that while we're the best state for business

[01:42:43] we've had a lot of economic challenges. Next slide. Not all of Virginia is growing at the same rate, and not all of Virginia has experienced recovery at the same rate. This slide is just a way of demonstrating from February of last year to about April of this year, the darker shaded areas have had higher levels of unemployment than the lighter shaded areas. It's just an easy way to look at the regional impact. I'll talk a little bit about what the industry areas have been that have suffered the most. Yes, ma'am. Yeah. Forgive me for interrupting,

[01:43:20] but my eyes aren't good enough. That light blue, so Southern Virginia has done better in terms of recovery than Northern Virginia. They've lost fewer jobs. They've had, so same thing got my attention when I saw this from my team. So the Southern Virginia simply had fewer jobs lost as a percentage of their workforce than these other areas the darker shaded areas so southern virginia southwest virginia and i think if i go to the next slide uh kevin well two more virginia's done better in the u.s this is simply a slide showing virginia in the dark blue our unemployment rate's better than the u.s

[01:43:56] and the next slide so let me back up i don't i don't know that i'm going to have this industry council slide here so leisure hospitality non-essential retail those industries have been the hardest hit and within those lightly shaded areas they simply less few lost fewer jobs than the darker shaded areas this is uh we asked vedp to do some projections on bringing virginia back to the employment levels uh that we were located in and you'll see about first quarter of next year although we're catching up that first quarter of next year i think virginia will be back at

[01:44:34] the employment levels we were um the next slide though and again because you're a statewide board I know you'll focus on the importance of this. Think about Virginia regionally and you start thinking about the urban crescent versus the rural horseshoe and you start realizing the difference in recovery here. The urban crescent is going to recover and has been recovering much faster than rural Virginia. So we, as we put together this blueprint, it's a statewide document, but we know that growth occurs along economic boundaries, not political boundaries.

[01:45:05] And so we want to make sure we're thinking about those regional boundaries. That's why we have regional meetings we we participate and understand the regional goals and objectives and we try to incorporate them into the blueprint recommendations heaven next slide one uh before i talk about the blueprint process i'll just close this section by talking about how this um covet has uh impacted different population groups much more severely and if you think about the economic challenges of that when you're putting together a new economic strategic plan you want to keep in mind that

[01:45:41] impact on these groups and how it has impacted them differently so this slide simply is a demonstration of how disproportionately some of those groups that are less educated minorities women and lower wage workers have been impacted in their unemployment rate another way on the next slide of showing it i think it's a little easier to look at if you look back at february of 20 versus february 21 and you see the dark blue of february 20 compared to the light blue of February 21, what you'll see in these specific population groups is a disproportionate impact

[01:46:19] of employment compared to the population at whole. So as we put the blueprint together, we're our advisory board and our steering committee is looking through multiple lenses. We're looking through regional lenses, which I just talked about, but we're also looking through lenses of making sure that we apply some equity to our recommendations. Next slide.

[01:46:42] last year as we started to lay the groundwork for blueprint and work with the general assembly we put forward through some work of the of the chamber board an equality of opportunity agenda and this recognizes that not all virginians are participating at the same level and so these are recommendations which we can send you a link to that we are leaning in on to help build the blueprint for 2030 on how do we close the education gap the employment gap and the entrepreneur gap we We also, for the first time as a chamber, endorsed some criminal justice reform so that

[01:47:18] we would not hold people outside the workforce opportunity because of some things in the past that may have been resolved and they have been restored and yet they still are not able to have full employment.

[01:47:33] So we leaned in on that last year. And I think the business community has a responsibility to do this and we'll have that as part of our blueprint update. forward to hearing your views on all these things let's go to the next section we'll talk about the blueprint process oh we'll send you this it's too small for me to read but i'll tell you we do have some specific recommendations on education around broadband work-based learning and some other areas that we can send you to consider as you all are thinking about public policy recommendations as well and soft skill development and again even under these there

[01:48:09] are more detailed recommendations our education recommendations come from human resource directors we have uh hr human resource people from our biggest membership that are in fact engaged in developing public policy recommendations for education so that's where our ideas are coming from not we're very interested in professional educators uh views as well but these are the things that we see that need to be done next slide so the blueprint process how are we doing it and what's our structure. And then the Blueprint Virginia 2030 Business Plan for the Commonwealth,

[01:48:47] we kicked it off last year. Next slide, Kevin. This is a diagram that is intended to tell you that it's an inclusive process. We have a steering committee, we have advisory board, we have strategic alliances with a lot of stakeholder groups. Over 100 groups are participating in the process itself, so it's not a chamber of commerce document, it's a business community document so all the go virginia regions are participating and supporting it we've invited school boards to participate all the university presidents participating the economic development community are participating so it's a comprehensive approach it takes about a

[01:49:25] year to develop and um and it's a consensus document we'll bring these recommendations back to our board steering committee advisory committee in the fall and our goal will be to present them to the governor elect in december of this year next slide so this is a road map that essentially says the same thing we kicked this off last year holding public hearings throughout the state meeting with stakeholders this is a great time for us to be visiting with your board to make sure we're hearing from you about recommendations that you would like to see in the blueprint as we put it forward as an advocacy document for the chamber of commerce next slide again these are virtual meetings that go virginia is holding for us

[01:50:05] yesterday i had the region seven with over 350 people on it's been amazing how even though we've been in a pandemic virtually we've had more people participate and they're able to be engaged in the surveys we give a little bit of a powerpoint on the region we hear from their region and then we hear people from people directly i think my favorite was uh these are open to the public so i was doing one in southwest virginia and i had university president speak community college president come on and speak and chamber come on and speak and then i got this little hand raised

[01:50:40] to this lady i didn't recognize i asked my staff to recognize her she is uh sitting on a in a rocking chair on this porch with her high pad and she was chewing something that wasn't gum and uh and she starts just telling me about education in the community and her thoughts on it and she wants to be included so i i i loved it took me back to public hearing days as the young mayor and i thanked her for

weighing in for participating so we have had every every access I had one of those in Northern Virginia yesterday come in on the Zoom call and talk about, you

[01:51:17] know, should we think about curriculum differently, should we think about money differently, we need to rethink education. It's interesting. I mean, average citizens have a lot of thoughts that you can hear from if you've been involved in the stream of gathering thoughts. So these regional meetings have been great. Next slide. Again, we do have a workforce and education conference that will be actually in person on october 20th we intend to invite invite the candidates for governor to this we would love for you all to attend we believe this will be in person this will be our first in-person conference october 20th so mark your calendars for that and eric

[01:51:54] will be sure to work with our comms team to send you all invitations to attend that event have the whole floor of the convention center i think we can do it socially distant we'd love for you to participate in this conference as well attended teacher and i were talking earlier this has been eight nine hundred people before i think some of you on the board and dr trent has actually spoken or been moderators at these events uh this year we're going to balance safety um but we're looking forward to having this in-person event it's where higher ed k through 12 all of us can come to come together to talk about this with our candidates for governor uh next slide so this is a busy org

[01:52:34] chart but i want you to know we have both a bottom-up process the bottom-up process includes listening tours regional approaches subject matter experts and industry specific councils coming up to the advisory board and then to a steering committee next slide our chairs of the steering committee are nasa keen who's the ceo of a multi-billion dollar company at saic and you may know ed bain who is the president of dominion energy virginia they chair the steering committee next slide and then uh we have a number of uh subcommittees that are in place as well

[01:53:12] and the next slide um obviously you know dr trend i do want to turn the program over to her for purposes of making this presentation acknowledge jennifer baird executive with altria who's her co-chair and they're overseeing all the recommendations for the entire workforce pipeline so early childhood k-12 certifications and higher education so i want to thank her for her willingness to the volunteer position and like yours and uh turn it over to her for for a few uh slides and some results so thank you great thank you so good morning everybody it's good to be here

[01:53:49] with the board of head once again um i want to express my gratitude as as barry did um and thanking you for allowing us to be here and to share and to have this conversation it's a very important conversation to have and then also i want to also again express my gratitude to barry in the chamber for asking me to co-chair this committee i've said it to him before i say it to a lot of people this is probably one of the most consequential um things that i'll be involved in and so i'm very humbled by the invitation to chair chair this committee as barry said jennifer and i are the

[01:54:28] co-chairs basically our job is to oversee the development of workforce and education component for um blueprint 2030 and um i will say that very very talked a little bit about this but i'm not sure you quite understand what a robust engagement system that they have established over the years this is i think the third blueprint that i've been involved with um i was involved in the very first one and at some capacity and the second one and so this is um but they have really i would say

[01:55:05] they've cornered the market on how to engage all of the right people at the right time and so part of what jennifer and i are also doing is helping them to identify stakeholders and helping them to

engage stakeholders across the state to be involved in this process so next slide please i'm gonna forget to say next slide so barry's gonna help me um so so this is this is who we are right we have a lot of areas in which we're focusing on but i like to say that workforce and education um our committee is really gets involved in all of the fun stuff right

[01:55:42] we get to take the long view uh and look at the education and workforce landscape over the over the years and then reimagine kind of like what you do every day or in your meetings here re-imagine what education can and workforce can be in the next decade and so applying some of the principles and applying some of the um the things that blueprint is prescribing through this process to our education and workforce system it's it's we really get to sit back and say okay now what where do we want to be what do we want to do and what do we want to look like in 10 years and so

[01:56:16] um like you and this what you do on this this board um this is like really a lot of fun to me right so being able to really um think about where we're going to go next slide please um so i will say that and very touch on this a little bit the recommendations um blueprint 2025 call for targeted improvements and targeted investments in k-12 early childhood education higher ed and what blueprint 2030 is doing is really building on those recommendations right and making sure

[01:56:52] that we are building on them that we are improving on them and that we're also incorporating some of the things that we've learned lessons that we've learned the valuable lessons that we've learned through coven 19 um also really embracing the um the the the positive and the resiliency of virtual education um one of the conversations that the conversations that that um barry and i had when he asked me to chair this was around equity um that is a major focus of what they're trying to

[01:57:26] do through this and so we'll be looking at that and then also just really creating connectivity um through workforce and education and so our our focus areas as you can see is early childhood education assistance improvements and accountability building these pathways and supporting equity as well as developing world-class talent next slide please so as i mentioned blueprint and as barry mentioned blueprint is a very very collaborative process we um we literally receive

[01:58:04] input from thousands and thousands i think he just mentioned 4 000 individuals one of the key ways that we do this is through our surveys. And so next slide, please. The Chamber has four -- uses four layers of serving for this process. The statewide -- there's a statewide comprehensive survey that they use. The Executive Committee surveys, as he mentioned, are around -- that are broken out on these policy areas. The regional meetings that are broken down along the go virginia regions and then they also have these signature events he talked about the

[01:58:42] economic development conference they are having a veterans conference coming up soon they had a health care conference and so that's also another way in which we survey our participants and make sure that they their voice is also heard and so the opportunity to really engage across the commonwealth and across stakeholders is pretty fast fast as it relates to blueprint 2030 um and it it really does give individuals who want to have a voice in this process there are ample opportunities for them to do so next slide please um so just to give you an example of some of the

[01:59:21] survey questions and some of the data that we collect through these surveys we um we asked this of each of the regions are asked these questions i'm not i can't remember exactly how many questions there are i think it's like 20 25 maybe i'm not sure it's almost 20 questions so these are just a couple of the

examples which areas do you have do you believe have the most impact on virginia's overall economic competitiveness by a large margin most of the regions say workforce and

[01:59:56] education and i think there's only three more regions that we're doing and this is every region so this is every region that has been surveyed so far next slide please and then the next example another example is if virginia can make additional investments in education and workforce development programs where should the additional investments go and you can see where the two top responses are internships and apprenticeships obviously in line with what you all did several years ago through the profile of a high school graduate and so this is kind of the data that we we we uh examples of

[02:00:33] the data that we have collected through these surveys um and this is going to be kind of the platform for how we we roll out or the platform for our um education and workforce um for blueprint virginia 2030. and with that i'm going to turn it back over to you great next slide please so again just save the date if uh you guys are available we'd love for you to participate and join us for october 20th obviously our economic summit we hope to present and actually unveil the blueprint that day in the high level recommendations and present it to the governor-elect uh and then

[02:01:12] if you want to participate directly the survey is available online um and we're collecting the statewide survey throughout the rest of the year next slide um always include this if you're a Chamber of Commerce, by the way. I can't forget this slide. We are privately funded and privately supported, but these companies have all leaned in and want to be part of and are part of Blueprint, so thank you to them. Next slide. Mr. Chairman, that concludes our formal presentation. Thank you for listening and thank you for your interest. I would be happy to have a dialogue on this and

[02:01:49] other related topics that Dr. Trent and I can respond to. Again, thank you for the, you know, very complete presentation about what you're doing uh you know the board clearly has some you know significant areas of overlapping interest with where the chamber is you know i don't know how specific your recommendations yet uh you know certainly as dr trent noted you know we have had a fair amount of uh discussion here and work done with regard to workforce and profile of a graduate is a good example of that and i think you know fully in line with what the chamber's objectives

[02:02:24] would be that is to have a legitimate career path and training in our schools for that legitimate career path. You know, I'll shift over for a second before I open this up to the board to the equity work that you mentioned. I think it's listed on your slide as a quality of opportunity agenda, in particular, you know, closing the achievement gaps. And I guess now I'm sensitized enough to say that when we say closing the achievement gaps, we mean by lifting up all groups as opposed to dumbing down the top group you know you can't be too

[02:02:57] careful in your speech these days you know the concept of closing the achievement gap has been around for quite some time now and frankly there has not been you know significant headway I'm not gonna say no headway because there has been some but there has not been really a demonstration that we've been able to fully realize the goal of closing that achievement gap some of this deals with, I think, our boards, and we had some discussion about this just yesterday, you know, sort of the recognition that education funding overall in the Commonwealth needs to be

[02:03:32] increased, that we are underfunding education as a category, and if we expect to have better results, then actually that is going to take more resources. And second, some of it deals with my view, and I think the board's view at this point, how the dollars are deployed. The board in the last two years has

prescribed with our constitutional ability standards of quality which had very specific recommendations or prescriptions as to how dollars ought to be deployed locally, or at least certain dollars ought to be deployed locally. You know, those changes or those

[02:04:10] proposed changes in policy, I guess, would be considered to have been revised out by the General Assembly since it's their right to revise whatever we prescribe and have not been adopted again you know Barry I think you and I had a discussion probably in December of 19 in person about this up in the governor's mansion I think we were at an event and had a very quick discussion about this and then of course COVID hit and sort of things stopped you know I think and I'll speak for the board on this you know we would very much like to be involved in the

[02:04:44] recommendation process we have spent a lot of time as a board doing you know what we think are research-based, evidence-based recommendations. And again, it's not just a traditional, we want more, it's, you know, we recognize if we keep spending in exactly the same way we're spending it today, although we might make some progress, we're not going to make the progress that, you know, all of us want to see. I don't know, you know, where in the process you are with regard to specifics. Honestly, I don't know how specific the blueprint gets. But if there is room in the process for our board, either through me or, you know, Dr. Wilson or any other representative

[02:05:21] from the board to get down to more detailed comments. You know, I think we would certainly as a body appreciate that and we look forward to working with the chamber as the General Assembly comes back into session and with the new governor, whoever they might be, to implement some of the things that we think are necessary to, you know, make meaningful change in the direction here to close that gap, and again, we want to lift up, not pull down anybody.

[02:05:52] And I don't know if you want to respond to that, Barry, or Deitra. If I could respond, I think Deitra can respond as well. Let me talk about the process first. So perfect timing right now for the process. We're in the summertime gathering information, gathering recommendations, parallel organizations to yours with other focus are actually sending us and sending eric and our policy team uh very detailed recommendations on big themes the past two blueprints have been aspirational in terms

[02:06:27] of goal setting and objectives but have included some level of detail so i'll just give an example when dr templin was running the community college that had a pilot program connecting with the uh the k-12 system and community college and george mason we call out those specific best practices in the blueprint as an example of what might be scaled for the state so there are broad themes but there are also some specific recommendations and in terms of the timing the summer is the

[02:07:00] perfect time we will begin in september to bring final focus on the actual recommendations that will be put before the October advisory board and steering committee so probably within the next five to six weeks would be a great time to present data present studies we're getting them from different groups and so for example the early childhood foundation has been working with us very collaboratively on studies they've done and recommendations they've done but the process is

[02:07:35] open now is the perfect time i was glad we were invited for today for that reason and let me uh turn to Dr. Trent to talk a little bit about some of the observations she has on funding and recommendations on results and outcomes and anything else you'd like to say of course about the process. Well I want to really start with the process and that is um as Barry said this is this is a wonderful

opportunity and the timing is great right um what the chamber has traditionally done has been to work with organizations throughout the summer but also working with the secretary of

[02:08:13] of education. I know when I was in ANWR in the administration, we met with Barry constantly about what the recommendations are around education. I know right now we would value your input. Eric has -- would have the large scale recommendations or the recommendations that have come in. We certainly -- I'm happy to work with him and whoever on the board to really discuss -- have some discussion around those recommendations and have your input in those recommendations i think that's very valuable this is your job like you said right this

[02:08:47] is this is where um you know you you have the evidence-based um data behind all this and so so we we welcome that so and i'm i'm happy to work with eric or barry or whoever um and you jamal whoever else who's interested on the board to really go through them and well think about the end game so for us the end game is advocacy policy and funding in the right places so the blueprint is really a platform if we if we if we get the recommendations right in the

[02:09:21] platform it gives us an opportunity as a chamber to turn on the advocacy spigot to 27 000 business members on a specific initiative so we've seen this formula work very well and we like to advocate for funding for specific areas if i could be uh that granular we for example um in economic development right now we've missed about 30 billion dollars of projects over 24 months because we don't have sites that are ready we don't have tier four tier five sites that are ready so we're advocating right now it's public information i sent this governor and generally

[02:09:59] for 150 million dollars of one-time money to build so many sites in every region so we might be able to get in that stream of economic development we are that specific when it comes to an initiative so if you have as a board some recommendations around any of those four pillars or other areas um we would put the concept in blueprint and then each year we would advocate from the blueprint for specific dollars to specific programs that's how this works over the next 20 24 to 48 months yeah and i would say also as an example um you know early on we had

[02:10:36] some challenges around getting early childhood education into the budget um the team really got involved in that and really advocated on behalf of that and now we have we are here today right so um you know this is this is a a a real partnership and as barry mentioned we come here with the same um you know the same motivation as you all and that's to making sure that all of our kids have an excellent opportunity in education and so we do that working with you and you are the experts

[02:11:11] and you are in this much deeper than either barry or i or anyone at the chamber so we welcome the input well you know certainly you know i appreciate being referred to as the experts although as a former secretary of education i don't know i'm not like you i know that you've got a fair amount of expertise in this area and frankly i know barry just by application has a fair amount of expertise in this area it would be helpful I think you know before you know y'all leave if we could coordinate you know perhaps with Miss Webb you know how those lines of communication are gonna go because so often you know time just begins to slip

[02:11:47] and I know that this time time frame is tight and you know I view this as an opportunity the board shouldn't miss to be involved in this project that's great anybody else I'm sorry to have started first I usually don't but I had a few things I wanted to say. They are never shy, but now.

[02:12:13] All right. Well, first, just thank you all. The Chamber's efforts on the blueprint generally and the focus on education workforce specifically are incredibly valuable to the commonwealth and we're grateful and I know a lot of that, Barry, is your personal push to help the Chamber serve the commonwealth in this way and you all been doing this over the longer term with in every round and more and more focus on education and workforce and I'm grateful you the heft you all bring to the conversation And your ability to sort of look across sectors

[02:12:52] So we all kind of get in our our little lanes and our silos and you all can step back and reach across and think about how the sectors connect cradle to career, so to speak, is really, really valuable. And I do know from my time as Dr. Trent knows in the McAuliffe administration that how valuable it was and particularly to the point you started with this continuity point, you know, where we turn over governors every four years.

[02:13:19] But, you know, how do we have continuity? And the fact that we were able when we were an incoming a brand new administration, to have your blueprint there as we walked in the door and know that that was not just a document you were handing us, but that that was what the chamber was gonna be advocating for, the business community had come together around those priorities was really valuable.

[02:13:42] I have one process suggestion and then just, I think, three comments on substantive areas. The process suggestion, in addition to meeting, I think it would be wonderful to have your leadership team meet with perhaps Dr. Wilson and Mr. Gecker or with or without the superintendent, you all will figure that out. In addition to that, I would suggest, and we're really grateful for the chance to give you input today, substantive input. In addition, I would suggest if you haven't already, the stakeholder group of what we call the stakeholders,

[02:14:21] usual suspects here on all our topics do meet together and they have some structure where they come together a group that includes the soup that's superintendents Association the VSBA so school board members superintendents teachers parents who am I forgetting but there is a the principal association of the curriculum group. Anyway, they all come together in varying degrees of collaboration and have in various ways over the years. It would be good to pull their ears into your

[02:15:01] vigorous conversation. Particular areas that I thought I would comment on, one is the early childhood. I'm really thrilled to see that as one of your identified focus areas. On that one, I would tie particularly to your continuity remarks. We've done various things in the early childhood over various governors, but in this administration there really has been a huge leap forward with potential for more federal money to come help fund the next level.

[02:15:31] And it would be wonderful if whoever the next administration is understands the value of some continuity on that work, and this shouldn't be political, it shouldn't be partisan at all. In particular, the current administration moved the ball forward not just on expanding formal pre-k schooling opportunities but has really moved the ball forward on the early childhood workforce issues which were huge and has moved the ball forward on how we ensure all of our all of our resources are working

[02:16:10] together towards quality early childhood experiences in both the public and private settings this the advances and i'm sure you're familiar with all this on the quality rating initiative um and and shifting the leadership over here and we we're uh we're still learning our ropes uh here in our oversight role and dr mann brings a wealth of experience to that which we're really grateful for but the it would be

wonderful to see those initiatives taken to the the next level, whoever the leadership is and you all can really help make that happen.

[02:16:46] You have your two focus areas of equity and talent. I love seeing them back to back and I think there's a big intersection of those and one of the items I'm sure Mr. Gecker et all will help raise up is our SOQ recommendations really do work at the intersection of equity and talent we understand from the research that getting our high quality teachers to our neediest kids is a crucial imperative and one we're not meeting yet.

[02:17:19] That our teacher shortages, our experienced teacher shortage, our quality teacher shortage are all that much more severe in our schools that are serving our most disadvantaged students. And I say, when we get to the point where the low income schools are hiring teachers away from the suburbs, you know, to both our urban high poverty communities and our rural needy communities, then we'll know we've gotten to a successful point and we are a long ways from that.

[02:17:52] But I think our SOQ recommendations with their focus on the intersection of equity and teachers as the crucial resource are valuable. One thing we don't address in the SOQ because it doesn't really fit in terms of, we don't have a mandate to set teacher salaries, but I think teacher salaries are crucial.

[02:18:12] And I would hope that you all will help support the effort to improve Virginia's standing. I know this from my, now my academic work on education policy that teachers coming out with a four-year degree are how they, their salaries compare to other four-year degree holders.

[02:18:34] It's just bottom of the barrel and it just can't work over the longer haul. So the teacher workforce, I really raise that up. And then one just very small but important thing, recognizing you're very focused within workforce on STEM kinds of fields.

[02:18:55] The work the department is doing on math pathways, I raise up for your consideration. And this really started with some of the community, if I understand correctly, the community college leadership started with focusing on how do we, they were looking back to the K-12 world and realizing kids coming from K-12 to community colleges didn't have the math skills, the numeracy skills they needed and recognizing that bumps in the road from students going from community college to four years and so started this pathways initiative that's now encompassing all sectors,

[02:19:33] and how do we help raise up the rigor level, but also smooth the pathway. And so I call that up for your consideration for something that might be worth endorsing, specifically that one of those things that doesn't necessarily cost extra money, it just means being innovative and forward thinking.

[02:19:49] - Thanks for those specifics. Thank you so much. - Dr. Wilson. - Just very quick couple of questions, and thank you all very much for your presentation and your support and your being here. And maybe it's too early to say, but I do recall you saying, Mr. Duvall, that you are gathering themes, that themes, comments from your surveys seem to be coalescing around certain themes.

[02:20:16] Maybe it's too early to share, but I'd be curious to hear a couple of those, one, two, as we think about what COVID-19 has taught us, right? So not necessarily the immediate reaction to COVID, but looking further ahead, 2030 and beyond, are there lessons learned that you are hearing as it relates to workforce and education that we will hold onto as kind of a positive remnant of COVID-19?

[02:20:50] - I'll be glad to address that. One thing that you have made, obviously you've heard this term before, the business community is interested in this theme of connecting learning to earning and that's just a general theme i speak with university presidents about this community college presidents about this and it doesn't diminish the business community's view of soft skills or non-technical skills but just if we can begin to express ourselves as a business community is that people will come through our education pipeline with all the skills to connect what they've learned to having an

[02:21:30] opportunity to be productive whatever they choose to be productive in connecting earning to learning is a is a theme around uh which i'm seeing emerge from surveys and and the business community um so i i'll mention that or anything do you want to talk about so i i haven't had a chance to really look at the surveys, and I was just trying to think if there are others that I've heard.

[02:21:58] I know that's the one, you know, connecting the learning to earning is the one that we talk about the most, and also we are beginning to talk about a little bit at George Mason even, so, but I haven't seen the results, I'm not sure. And then, again, these are early results.

[02:22:15] Yeah. the lessons learned is just the need to make sure that every student is connected at home with technology that allows them to continue their learning. What does that look like? I think it's what the governor is doing right now, significant investments in upgrading our broadband technology and our connectivity. That's important, I think, for certainly the education system. It's important for the business community. What I think we haven't realized yet is the potential for helping

[02:22:54] small metros, inner city, and rural Virginia to come back in the stream of commerce by creating employment centers outside of heavily populated metro areas. I think this is a national opportunity for us that we should view, I get a chance to say things like this publicly, we should view the implementation of broadband across rural America as seriously as leaders did in the 1930s and 40s about creating co-ops and electrification of America. We should view it that seriously.

[02:23:30] And what the federal government did was made it possible by having the right grant programs that could be paid back to allow that to happen. So I'd love to see some big national thinking on this to the extent that we can have state thinking and state leadership and state money to help us because the connectivity of a child going through school is just as important to me as the connectivity of a remote worker. Well, I will say, why is Virginia's unemployment rate and why are our revenues at the state level doing so much better than so many other states? It's because we have a high degree of knowledge-based workers, and it's because those workers have been able to

[02:24:06] continue. Six weeks after the pandemic hit, I was talking to CEOs around the state. It wasn't uncommon for me to have one say to me, oh, 9,000 people working for me, got 840 of them remote working, fully operational, 90% of their workforce remote working within three weeks. And they invested in the technology so that at their home, they would be just as secure. We need to think about education in a longer term. You asked me about long term. I see that as the theme for us in Blueprint, as well as the near term connecting learning. I hope that answers your question.

[02:24:42] And I just wonder what this increased connectivity can do to our teacher shortage, right? You know, when you look at where we are lacking our teachers in some of the most hard-to-serve areas, wouldn't it be great if we could zoom in some of our teachers from Fairfax County, some of the, you know, the best schools that we have, into Petersburg?

[02:25:06] And, you know, what would that mean for our students, right? So we do have a lot of opportunities to really think about, you know, this new world that we're in and how do we, like I said, reimagine education in a way that we can really explode in the next and make sure that equity is there across the board.

[02:25:26] so. Okay. Dr. Duran, then Dr. Mann. Thank you for being here. Nice to see you, Dr. Trent, as always. One area, as you highlighted, a data point you shared around equity was that 45% of those earning less than $22 an hour were Hispanic. And I think an opportunity here for a partnership, because in Northern Virginia, there are some good examples of adult education partnering with 10 to 12 public school systems, community colleges, to help prepare in the workforce certifications all kinds of things but the barrier we often see for that particular

[02:26:00] population is the lack of ability to understand english and and being able to develop english and proficiency level even pass the certifications i've personally seen them in their courses really knowing and being able to do the content the hands-on and discussing with them in spanish how excited they are what they're learning but they're not able to pass some of the assessments so i would love to see as part of your blueprint a real investment from the state in adult esl or high school students um really a robust uh statewide effort on how we need to make sure that

[02:26:34] so many of those individuals that 45 have the ability but don't you know to actually learn the content to actually partake in these workforce development but yet there's a barrier for them there and so how do we join and as you said a minute ago i think you said you're showing examples there's some good examples of how that's happening with the k-12 public school division community college and then we're partnering together to make sure that our in many cases those are our parents that we're serving in the public schools right and so i think that would be a robust um specific example of how we can help develop yeah thank you for that wonderful recommendations thank you all

[02:27:11] dr man like my colleagues i share my enthusiasm for the presentation and all of the great information you're sharing and of course it's not going to be surprising and I'm going to reinforce just a couple of comments that Ms. Halton made but also lift up another point related to early childhood had it not been for the board meeting yesterday I would have been on the call for the Northern Virginia region that you all hosted on yesterday but I would like to say that you know I it is it's great to hear that you're engaging with the ECF around early ed and thinking very specifically about some of the ways in which there are some specific

[02:27:49] recommendations that could be made to help support what needs to happen in early childhood but I'm also thinking about the importance of the business community separate and apart from the advocacy support around public funding because early ed is an area that is public-private right it doesn't have a a dedicated public funding stream that supports its ability to provide care and education birth forward and i think there is a real opportunity to engage the business community and thinking

[02:28:25] about some of the very entrenched financing strategy financing challenges that the sector faces we tend to think about preschool education as sort of the education domain and child care is now integrated. This board has charge over that area. And I feel like if the workforce is going to be strong in our region and businesses are going to be strong, focusing on how we are supporting the cost of care is critical. And where is the creativity within the business sector

[02:29:03] to really help us solve that problem? Certainly public funding is important, but I don't think that's the sole answer and so there is an opportunity to delve into that and i'd be curious about your thoughts i know early ed has been a part of the blueprint for census inception which has been outstanding but we have a lot of work to do if we're going to stabilize a sector that's vital to the economic vitality of our of the commonwealth i'll start with a quick story probably six years ago, seven years ago, I asked Mike Petters to come and speak at an education

[02:29:43] conference, one of the conferences that we were holding on education. He currently is president of Huntington Ingalls with Jones Newport Shipbuilding. They have 45,000 employees. They have 20,000 employees, 25,000 now in Virginia. He opened his comments by saying he wanted to talk about a national security issue and what he thought was the most important national security issue in America. And he went on to say it was early childhood education. And he laid out an entire presentation on that topic and ultimately found its way in the Wall Street Journal as an

[02:30:18] op-ed. And he's probably one of the best messengers. And he stated it this way. He said, I have one customer is the United States Navy. We build the ships for the United States Navy. I know I'm going to have that customer 20 years from now. I know how to finance those projects for the next 20 to 40 years, but I don't have a guarantee that I'll have a workforce to produce it. And the workforce 20 years from now is in early childhood stages today. And so it was such a clear statement on behalf of the business community. And I think if you look at the business community in terms of

[02:30:57] size and scope, the larger sectors are funding and can fund and should be asked to fund a number of these initiatives. And I think there is a growing willingness to do that. We, through our blueprint, are not simply advocating for public policy, but we're also advocating for private policy. And I think we can capture some of your recommendations today and make sure they're part of the blueprint process. I know there's a lot of funding coming in from the private sector.

[02:31:24] I don't know how efficient it is, and I don't know how broad-based it is, but we should lean in on that. And I thank you for that recommendation, because we want to ensure that we capture it. But it is a priority. And the last thing I'll say is something Dr. Trent said earlier.

[02:31:41] For whatever reason, the business community broadly gets a lot more credibility and gets to weigh in on things than some of the other stakeholders in the world. And I think we should take that responsibility seriously. And the one way we did in 2012 and 2013 was moving early childhood education out of the political arena where it was a right or left issue and it was a social issue.

[02:32:03] By putting it in the blueprint, it became an economic issue. And by putting it in the blueprint, it depoliticized it. So I was able to work in the last 10 years with Republican governors, Democratic governors, Republican members of the General Assembly, Democratic members of the General Assembly to advance those causes.

[02:32:22] So I hope that the lessons from that can be applied to some K through 12 ideas that I'm hearing relative to how do we focus investment? How do we spend our dollars? Can we pay differentially for different areas for teacher salaries that we have different needs?

[02:32:40] Believe me, those are market-based principles that work. And we would be all in at supporting those and depoliticizing those if that's something that's helpful for you all. But thank you for your

comments and for your recommendations. Do you have anything to add? I have nothing to add. Dr. Lane asked for a few comments.

[02:32:56] Yeah, thank you. And I'll just offer the opportunity to speak directly with department leadership if you want, as always. And I know Ms. Holton mentioned all the associations, and Dr. Trent, I can make an introduction to VPAC. They kind of all sit together now and have a coalition where you don't have to go to each individual.

[02:33:14] That'd be great. A couple of thoughts on slide 20. You don't have to go to the slide. But on slide 28, you talk about promoting the soft skills. And I would just encourage that we work together on using the same nomenclature.

[02:33:33] In the ed world, the board has adopted a profile of a Virginia graduate. They talk about the five C's as being the critical skills. When you look at what you list as the soft skills, communication, problem solving, teamwork, leadership, that's essentially our five C's. And I think that if we can get the business community talking about the five C's in the way that the education community is, I think that will just bring some synergy.

[02:33:56] Then to the core slide 39, which is where you list the five areas, not for today, but I think we could maybe in bullet two think about how to define system improvements to be a little bit more direct.

[02:34:15] Is that the funding system? Is that the education delivery system? So on and so forth. I have some ideas on that for another time. I have the benefit of this being my second time seeing it too. so the but the the broader points that i had and i one of this echoes something miss holton said i i really feel like any blueprint has to have a teacher focus on it the word teacher has to be there because we're we have a looming crisis with the retirees post-covid and you know and the shortage issues and we had some of those issues even before and then the other one for me and and

[02:34:54] this could be wrapped in the system improvements but with what we've seen with the nape results in Virginia. I think that we really need to have a specific literacy focus somehow so that it's clear that this isn't just a K-12 issue, but something we really need to do as a community. And then my last thought is I obviously appreciate the fourth bullet on supporting education equity. I would love to hear ideas later, not today, on how we can depoliticize that, because I think that that

[02:35:29] should be a nonpartisan issue as well. We'd love to have those. I know we're taking notes and capturing your thoughts, but if you have specific recommendations around language for teachers, whether it's teacher pay, credentialing, retention, if there are statistics that you know that we could include as motivation for these policies, please provide those directly to us Well, thank you.

[02:35:57] Thank you. We value that. Thank you so much. And Dr. Anderson. Mine is more of a comment. I was going to refrain just from offering it, but once you quoted my CEO and you reinvigorated his passion that he is so good at articulating that we have, which is a focus on the workforce and not only are we keeping him safe and sending him home every day, but where in the world are we going to get him from?

[02:36:25] So the discussion around workforce development is very familiar to me. And the comment I was going to offer was more just complimentary of this initiative. I've had the privilege of being a part of this as a representative of Huntington Ingalls.

[02:36:44] And I participate in a lot of regional workforce initiatives, efforts, so many of them doing so many great things, and so many of them doing a lot of the same things, and so many of them with such great intent but such broad brush opportunities and focus that it's really hard to kind of really zero in on actionable things that can can make a difference and the best part of the presentation that I enjoyed today was the earlier slides where you talked about your vision very succinctly and your mission very succinctly that's one of the hardest things to stay anchored in do anything with the regional kind of focus on it preaching to the choir got

[02:37:21] it but my whole point was is that I just wanted to compliment this initiative because it is very easy to look at workforce issues in the here and now and it's out it's almost overwhelming so it's like if you don't get your arms around it and do something now about the pipelines now then you know how are we going to kind of get from under it's very rare to find an organization that recognizes the importance of that but says you know what we've got enough people working on the right now we need to be looking five ten years down the wrote in a very strategic focused way.

[02:37:52] And that's what I appreciate about this group. You mentioned before that survey information is still coming in. I did sit in on one of the calls where you guys had briefed out some initial survey feedback. One of those survey takers did recommend that there'd be great opportunity and alignment for Blueprint to partner with the Board of Education and get this in front of the Board of Education as soon as possible.

[02:38:19] And so I know you're still reviewing your survey information, but you guys are still actionable on things, whether you realize it or not. That was a recommendation that was presented in the previous. Because I think it is an important partnership. I think the ideas that have already come up today and just the potential that these organizations have to really influence change, I think it's really good.

[02:38:39] So I just really wanted to give a plug. Because I sit on a lot of calls, a lot of committees, a lot of good things happening, but a lot of times it's easy to get distracted. and just to see your stakeholder membership, how much that's grown. That's a great equation for paralysis by analysis, where you get too many people in the room and you don't really move.

[02:38:59] And that's quite the contrary with this group. Been impressed so far, looking forward to what could come of it. Thank you. - Thank you for your comments. Thank you all for having us today. Thank you, Mr. Chair, and we look forward to continuing to work with you. And thank you for the suggestions that have come across so far. Thank you. - Great.

[02:39:14] Thanks again for being here. It's always good to see you all. - Thank you. - Good to see you all. - Okay, we will move on to, commend to you the written reports and then we'll move on to discussion of current issues.

[02:39:38] Anybody have any current issues they would like to discuss? Ms. Holton? - Thank you. Well, I did wanna raise up the topic that we heard about in public comment and recognizing the opportunities limits of our authority I'm interested in hearing the board's thoughts on what if you all know how passionately I feel about my Richmond Public Schools and and

[02:40:14] our our partnership with them on behalf of the students and so I'm just interested in what if any I mean I think we all recognize that actual building can school construction is probably outside of our purview in any real direct way but it raises the conversation we heard raises up some more general issues and i recognize that you know there's some really good things going on in the city i know that the uh for

those of you who may not have seen the reports the graduation rate in rps went up by like 10 percentage points this year was a huge game particularly among the latino community

[02:40:51] where frankly the graduation rates have been abysmal and and they're actually moving towards reasonable and and there's some other other gains that have been made so there's some things going right but there's still some real remaining challenges and I know we are deeply engaged the department is deeply engaged with the city through the school improvement process and I guess I just my question would be or the would be how can the board be helpful to the department's efforts on school improvement and you know particularly with respect to Richmond City.

[02:41:27] - Mr. Gecker, I can level set just a few things so that all board members know some of the activities going on, of course, if that's okay with you, please. The Richmond Public Schools is under an MOU, they're one of our five districts, and several months ago we identified governance as a potential concern, it was in their academic review and addressed in certain places.

[02:41:54] And so we asked them by letter to adopt a new governance manual, and they did not have a formal one, at least that they were following. And we gave them a deadline of July 1st. And I'm pleased to say they did do that.

[02:42:11] And so I think that that was really our first step, just to make sure that they were structured there. I thought a lot of the comments you heard today was around governance and how they govern. And so I think that we continue to support them there. We also do, as part of the MOU, require school board training, and certainly we address best practices in that.

[02:42:32] Right now, their primary partner for that is the VSBA, and they do that twice a year. In addition to that, the board president and I meet with their board twice per year to review where they are on their own strategic plan and, at the same time, our corrective action plan and work on strategies there.

[02:42:55] And then, of course, the school improvement team is there almost on a daily, weekly basis. We approve every purchase order as an example, every hire, and we are in the process of working with all of our MOU school districts to develop some summaries of the activities of the previous year.

[02:43:15] And so those are not complete yet, but when those are complete, I'd be happy to bring you a summary of activities so you have a sense of the things going on, but that doesn't mean that we can't do more i just want to make sure everybody knows some of the things that we do uh with richmond and that governance was specifically addressed in the last six months so as a follow-up dr lane for into it ms holton said for the parents and the folks that came here who will be reaching out to them and what might we be able to share with them about what we can do what we are going to do obviously i think they're aware of the mou they shared that in their public

[02:43:50] comment but i would love for us to have some meaningful conversation with them um after they that came to us today to talk about what it is that we can and can't do. Mr. Gekker tried to do that and did that well at the end of their public comment, but I think a more meaningful conversation.

[02:44:06] Can you talk to us about what that might look like and what you can do? - Yeah, every person that writes into public comment or even speaks of public comment, hears back from a member of the staff. It's not always the same person, but certainly we'll follow up with them directly. And that's what we do.

[02:44:28] You mentioned they worked on governance issues through the MOU agreement. And so within, I know we can't talk about the specifics of the agreement, but I do get curious about when districts are under MOUs for whatever reason, are we focusing on whether they're doing the things they're supposed to do?

[02:44:51] I mean, to create a structure around governance and have policies and procedures that govern that, Do we also look at the extent to which they're living by those things that they create as a result of the corrective action engagement effort?

[02:45:09] I'm just curious about that. I think that we are much more active in ensuring that they're doing what they say they've done in the administration. The board and elected officials is a little bit more of a challenge because they're not hired by the school division.

[02:45:29] I mean, I know they get a salary, but they're hired by the citizens and they they respond in the way that they feel like is appropriate to citizens. And there's not accountability for jobs and things like that. And then certainly the way that that person engages with the community is also up to interpretation.

[02:45:51] Right. That they may feel they may engage with the community in other ways than the folks in public comment may suggest. And so that that's a little bit more complex. we that's a probably a long way of me saying we can't make board members do anything but certainly we can provide them best practices and i think we do that no i i meant more so in terms of if you have a governance if you've created rules that dictate how you're going to um create periods for comment input i really mean the technicalities not so much whether you're satisfied with the

[02:46:26] outcome or not of having deployed your process i'm more wondering about it seemed like we heard in comment there were some questions about whether there was even a following of releasing information in enough time for public comment i mean the things that really go to the technicalities of what do your rules suggest about right and uh um again whereas we do not place that that is that That should be self-policed by the board and the board chair, frankly, but you as a board

[02:47:03] could create rules for yourself and at the board meeting vote to suspend the rules. And that happens from time to time. I think James points out one of the difficulties of the entire MOU process right now.

[02:47:22] I will say that six years ago, we were much less involved in the MOU jurisdictions than we are today. And even today, the levers that this board has are pretty limited.

[02:47:39] And I would say that, you know, what we try to do, and, you know, James can, you know, fill in and correct some of this. But, you know, clearly it is now the department's belief, and I think our belief, that the leadership of the divisions matter.

[02:47:55] that includes not only the superintendents, and as you know, with all the MOU jurisdictions, we have the ability to at least interview and approve, in a sense, although not final approval, you know, the superintendent candidates, but also governance from the board sense, which is why, you know, things like the governance manual in Richmond became such an important issue.

[02:48:19] You know, we can't, though, deal with how individual board members relate to their constituents. that's past our purview, and really, you know, the reason I think we get to talk at all about board governance and then, you know, division governance, so the elected officials, elected slash

appointed, depending where you are, and then the, you know, hired superintendent is because all the evidence suggests that, you know, the leadership does matter even up to the school board level. You know, I will say, and, you know, we have not had this discussion specifically with

[02:48:57] Richmond, but we have had it with another jurisdiction, you know, how sort of the public dissent sometimes adversely impacts the ability of the division to do their job to educate the kids. And, you know, there is, not that we expect unanimity in every board, but there, we do expect at least a focus of the boards on improving educational outcomes as opposed to potentially some other issues at times.

[02:49:27] And, again, this is not a Richmond-specific thing because it has come up elsewhere. You know, we at some point need to make a decision, you know, how involved in local life we are going to be. That's in part a policy, and, you know, we're going to be restricted by code and constitution.

[02:49:47] But we have, I think, as a body and as a department, stayed a little bit away from, and I'm not saying this is inappropriate. I mean, it really is a policy decision that at some point we ought to talk about, you know, interfering dramatically in the local life.

[02:50:07] That is, we have, as a body and as a department, respected the constitutional concept that the local, that operation of a local school division is within the purview of its board and have not tested the limits of what that means, particularly with regard to, you know, the MOU jurisdictions.

[02:50:23] You know, I think as we place a higher emphasis right now on the Office of School of Equality, then, and I see this respectfully, you know, in terms of what their role ought to be, is we increase the resources given to the idea that we are going to, as a state, come in and assist jurisdictions in achieving a quality outcome.

[02:50:50] We need to discuss how far we are willing to go and test the limits, if you will, of state versus local. And, you know, again, I'm not prepared to answer that question today at all. But I do think as we move forward, it is a legitimate question.

[02:51:10] And, you know, it's been interesting to me. You know, I was in local government before this. And, you know, certainly, although we might disagree, the one thing we agree on is the state's got no right to tell us to do anything, right? You know, we could have 3-2 votes all the time, except when the issue is, can the state tell us something and then it's a clear 5-0, no, you can't.

[02:51:35] So, you know, perhaps nothing builds consensus as much as our intervention, maybe we ought to intervene everywhere, not just getting there. But no, it's a policy discussion, you know, worthy of some time. And again, if the direction of the department continues to increase resources toward school improvement in those divisions that, by code, come under our wing a little bit, it's something we probably ought to do sooner rather than later, quite frankly, because it is unclear now what the guidelines, what our guidelines are.

[02:52:13] I will say, again, that the department, in my view, and just having seen it over a six year period, has done more recently in terms of stressing certain things, you know, good governance, both at the board level and at the superintendent level, and then moving on down through the building level than we had been doing.

[02:52:37] And again, not because of any lack of, you know, any desire in the department's personnel not to do certain things, but it was just directional and resource-based. I mean, we used to have a single

person essentially doing this stuff. And, you know, I don't know where the department will go under, you know, whatever comes next.

[02:52:59] But if it is in the direction of enhancing those resources, you know, we ought to have policy there. And, you know, right now also under the MOUs, you know, the board has very, the board is board, not the BDOE. But the board has got, you know, almost no rights except to the required meeting with the superintendent, school board chair, school board vice chair, and Dr. Lane and myself.

[02:53:30] I mean, that's really what we have. And I'm not sure as we go forward that, you know, we should continue that or perhaps we ought to give our board a few more rights. But there is no point in taking rights if we're not going to exercise them in a positive way.

[02:53:47] I mean, the worst thing we can do is, I think, say we're now stepping in and then not have the ability to make things better. Yeah, Dr. Wilson. So I do think what I heard, I think we all did, was the group of speakers asking for help, almost help us know what to do as much as do something, help us know what to do.

[02:54:18] And so I think to Dr. Duran's question about staff and the way we respond, to the extent that it's appropriate, Dr. Lane, does it make sense as staff responds to speakers to help in some ways to help people think through what the avenues available to them may be?

[02:54:45] I know that that is a very slippery slope, but notwithstanding the board's policy conversation, there is an immediate need that these folks have expressed to us. And so how do we position ourselves best to be responsive without being inappropriately leading?

[02:55:07] And I do think it is a balance. And that's what I hear people asking, to help us know what to do. And certainly, I think the team does a nice job of responding with where you should direct if we can't support you.

[02:55:26] In this specific case, whereas many of the comments were couched in how we can improve governance, and I'd suggest some of the ways we've done that, it really was a concern with a specific decision that the board made, and one that I think is within their legal rights.

[02:55:44] And as you suggest, Dr. Wilson, it is a slippery slope. I mean, you and I, a number of us have been here long enough to remember all the discussions about, for example, special ed, and if we, you know, areas where we didn't have a lot of control, and I'm not, and I think everybody was very sympathetic, but I can not imagine us having staff or the board give advice to all of those people who spoke before us in those days about how to accomplish the goal you're looking to accomplish,

[02:56:22] let alone deciding whether the board thinks that the goals the speakers are looking to accomplish are, in fact, the correct goals for the jurisdiction. And so, you know, I'm very, you know, all of us who grew up in local government, very, very sensitive to the need and, you know, the desire to respond to the public.

[02:56:47] But, you know, I really caution that we stay within our lane. We do what it is supposed to do. I will also say that it is my experience, limited though it may be, that sometimes, you know, conversations that are not immediately reported to the press, you know, may have more impact than conversations that may in fact end up immediately reported to the press, you know, and which is not to say I don't believe in transparency and full disclosure and all that stuff. But I mean, all of

[02:57:22] us know, you know, at times positions harden prematurely when they are brought to light, you know, too quickly, when in fact reasonable compromise or reasonable solutions could have been found had the dialogue been allowed to continue privately for a little while longer.

[02:57:40] And so, you know, I hesitate to, you know, say that that's a path we ought to go down, which is not to say again, I responded to those folks, you know. So, but it was not, you know, here's what you're going to do.

[02:57:56] It's we are going to discuss this. And I think we are, in fact, discussing it. And on that point, I will say just because they may do something within their legal rights and therefore we don't step in doesn't mean we don't disagree from time to time with some of the decisions.

[02:58:12] I won't speak to the specific case. And we offer our advice on that all the time. And sometimes it's taken, sometimes it's taken. So I think that working to be respectful of the local role Absolutely crucial and I appreciate you all's careful guidance on that.

[02:58:30] I do think that just hearing the passion today helps raise up for me the question of what is our role? And one thing that is our role is making sure that we do our oversight role of the whole school improvement system that we have put in.

[02:58:51] I mean, the school improvement system is part of our SOAs. I mean, it is part of our responsibility. And we have instituted a system that does involve more robust engagement between the department and systems divisions that have been identified as not yet serving the students as well as we hope and want them to.

[02:59:17] And so this, you know, these five divisions that have been identified as having sufficient challenges as to need MOUs, we do have more opportunity and responsibility to make sure our system is working well vis-a-vis those five jurisdictions.

[02:59:36] And so in that spirit, I would say, I mean, I understand the president and superintendent's emphasis on the authority we don't have, but we do have some authority, you know, withholding funding in certain circumstances is one.

[02:59:53] And one, we don't want to exercise lightly because it impacts students and we can only exercise it in very limited circumstances according to our SOA structure. And yet, it's not that we have no authority, and I would encourage that we use this occasion to make sure we're doing everything we can to increase our own understanding of how our school improvement system is working, and it was also addressed in the JLARC report, which we know that it's not working at optimal level, partly because of staffing issues,

[03:00:30] but what can we do to help enhance that system, even if it's not gonna lead to some kind of immediate action item for the board, it's helpful for us to understand more about what is and isn't working about our school improvement system.

[03:00:46] So all of that to say, I'd love to have, and I know we do get occasional updates, but I'd love to have more regular updates or even just a soon update on all of our MOU jurisdictions and how are they doing and what are we doing help them do better and what's working and what's not that kind of a conversation i think that's fair and i certainly don't expect i mean i would certainly expect that we can have more regular updates although again cautious because you don't want to impede progress when progress is in fact

[03:01:22] being made albeit not yet showing up in the data we keep i would ask that as we discuss this you tried to separate out the role of the board from the role of the department and you know we have seen in the popular press recently some blurring of the lines and confusion about what is the board and what is the department and it's not that i'm trying to drive a wedge between us and the department that's not the point at all but the truth is that and again i think i mentioned this

[03:02:01] you know our mous give great rights to the department give very few rights to the board and you know i am certainly would be happy to make changes in how we do the mous to provide more rights at the board level you know i remember talking about my first board meeting when we did the petersburg mou and everybody was all excited i'm thinking well this gives no teeth to anybody you know there were really no ways for the board to intervene i'm thinking why is everybody so happy well i mean we were happy because we were you know saw some progress coming but in terms of

[03:02:40] what what rights it gave us you know pretty minimal you know from the lawyer's perspective and uh but just as we talk about this and frankly as you see it in you know there was one commentator down in one of the Norfolk papers that I actually called and said, you know, on one of the political issues of the day, he said, you mentioned the board. I said, there's no evidence the board has done anything you've said. And they said, well, the department. I said, well, we are not the department. You know, if you look at even things like, you know, I was with some folks this morning talking about, you know, the masks, you know, the advice there. I mean, people think we do that.

[03:03:20] But in truth, as far as I know, there's not a single member of the board who was involved in and giving advice on the masks and policy that just came out yesterday. Purely department and executive branch. So I'm not fussing about it, but I think that as we talk, we also need to be careful not to blur that line.

[03:03:40] - That's very helpful, I appreciate the reminder. On the particular, the authority to withhold funds under certain circumstances, is that board or department or is board acting on department recommendation? - Actually it's mandatory. So that is a board authority item and the other board authority item obviously is just our ability to take into account the operation of our current school improvement system as we think through the SOAs that put it into place.

[03:04:09] So, but yes, very helpful clarification, thank you. - And that specifically that language states that should a board not be in compliance for the corrective action plan, you shall reduce their funds.

[03:04:25] And they met that deadline on the governance piece. Anybody else on that topic? President Gecker? Yes, ma'am. I would like to say, to chime in with everyone.

[03:04:43] I was very impressed with the speakers who came in today with their passion and their organization as you gave them credit for that. And this is a very timely conversation because I was struggling with those same thoughts while they were speaking. and i've been thinking about how other school systems even though they may not be under the mou right now and school facilities and and all of the issues going on with the with the inequity of school funding and facilities or not funding but the facilities and older schools and i'm just wondering how is that going to impact us as we move into the future because workplace conditions

[03:05:23] are one of the main reasons why we retain teachers or we lose teachers and in the condition of our schools is very important especially on our end of the state and it's it's very upsetting and it's confusing

and it's a very hot topic right now and i want to thank everyone for going into the depth that you have and um president gecker you helped me to clarify a couple of points there and i appreciate what you were saying with the role of the board and the role of the doe and thank you And we're at a precarious point right now, and it's very well said, and I appreciate it.

[03:06:00] Thank you. Thank you. Mr. Geck, I can just respond to Ms. Davis-Faugh real quick. I think the best lever the board has on the facilities piece is this forthcoming item on the standards of quality we mentioned yesterday. You put it in the standards of quality, and then we can hold them accountable like an MOU district if they're not in compliance.

[03:06:21] But we're going to need some time on that. Okay. Dr. Mann. One thing I was going to not say, but I feel compelled because I guess I'm thinking about the conversation we're having and it's making me appreciate the complexity of pushing for change and how understanding rules and process and where levers are and aren't. And it's just mind blowing to think about how you have to be sophisticated about those things in order

[03:06:59] to really get things done, make change happen. And it's not something that, you know, it's just, I'm just kind of left very struck by that reality and what communities face as they are truly trying to save their children and the opportunities that their children should be having.

[03:07:30] Dr. Mann, that's what I was inarticulate in expressing, because communities don't necessarily understand all of the levers, and so to the extent that we can help educate, but I was not as eloquent as you were in that, and so thank you for clarifying it and making that statement so plain. I agree. Very well said. Thank you. I think we all feel that, but not but, and,

[03:08:06] you know, I think we also have to recognize that change in the context of government is a long process, right? And so you have people wanting immediate results on certain things that we're just not geared to do. I remember yesterday's lunch talking about the, how long it takes to get regulations through the process, right? You're looking at 18 to 24 months just to get regs through. So I think, you know, as part of, you know, Barry's presentation today, one of the things

[03:08:42] most meaningful is the long-term view and continuing to set the goalposts. When we first prescribed the SOQs, you know, we talked about basically having policy bend toward it over a decade. I mean, that's, I'm hoping it occurs sooner than that. But realistically, what we do is we set out markers and hope that the policy bends toward those markers.

[03:09:07] And, you know, there are days when that is an incredibly frustrating thing, and there are days when you see incremental progress that you think, you know, it's all been worth it. But I can tell you that, you know, eight years from now, I think we'll be happier with where we are than we might be today as we continue to lay out the long term, which, you know, is the role of the board at this point.

[03:09:30] I know we have some immediate things we deal with, But by and large, we continue to set out the long-term vision. And it is, you know, you can't be human and not react to the clear anguish in the people who are here today as they talk about educating their children.

[03:09:48] You just cannot. But, you know, we continue to do what we can do. And I think, you know, I would take the board's discussion today as sort of authority to discuss, Certainly at the next meeting we have with RPS, the issues that were raised before us today, you know, and, you know, talk about, you know, stuff we might shy away from in other circumstances.

[03:10:17] I think we, you know, can't shy away from when it's been brought to our attention in this way. All right. I know it's now afternoon and, you know, frankly, given as quick as the agenda went this morning, I thought we'd be out of here at 11.

[03:10:34] But I would just like to say, you know, the next couple years, you know, the plan is to, you know, continue to develop the SOQs, continue to march down the work plan. I do think we're going to do a fair amount of work on the importance of building leadership and how we do that.

[03:10:53] Hopefully, you know, the SOA revisions will come through fairly soon. But, you know, I've been pretty happy with the amount of work this board has done in pretty important subject areas. And, you know, I always leave out early childhood because I, you know, just yield to the experts on it.

[03:11:13] But clearly, as the board, you know, will now have control over, you know, the entire process, basically, birth to, you know, grade 12, you know, we have a lot of work to do to fulfill the mandate to provide a high quality education system for all the children of the Commonwealth. So look forward to the next couple of years of the journey. Dr. Duran. I was waiting for that conversation to change. I am co-chairing on behalf of invitation from Superintendent Lane, the culturally responsive and inclusive education

[03:11:50] practices group. Great. And we are at the final stages of working towards bringing forth some recommendations for the board and some will be for the general assembly some will be departmental changes so i just want to let everyone know that i'm really excited um to have served in that role and thank you dr lane for the invitation to serve on that role um co-chairing uh with um the dean from dr dare as well as um some general assembly members senator voisco as well who helped lead the the charge to have it put in coat that we had to have this so it's really good to have this happening

[03:12:22] Because I think now in the time when equity has been a discussion point that has been malaligned and not exactly spoken about in truth, having the ability for school divisions to be given the guidance and the direction and the requirement to focus on the type of learning that our students are experiencing.

[03:12:44] so that all students' stories are being told is very important. So I'm looking forward to bringing these forward to you all as a liaison from the State Board. That should be coming fairly soon in the next couple of months. Great. We appreciate your service there.

[03:12:59] Can't think of anybody better to do it. All right, then. I think that covers all we wanted to cover today. We'll see you in a couple months. Dr. Davis-Vault, we hope to see you in person soon. Thank you, sir. We are adjourned.

